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NEXT SOFTWARE ACADEMY

CAREER GUIDE & WORKBOOK

US Remote Job Playbook

Find legitimate remote work, get accepted, and start earning: AI training, freelance marketplaces, and remote jobs

71
opportunities with direct links

30
rated Apply Now

51
documented worker outcomes

21
copy-paste AI career prompts

AI Training & AI Startups · Freelance Marketplaces · Remote Jobs · AI Resume & Interview Workflows

No promises of employment or earnings. Verify every listing before you rely on it.

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Start Here: Your First 90 Minutes

This playbook is built to be *used*, not just read. If you are out of work, between jobs, graduating, or switching careers, you need three things today: legitimate places to apply, a resume that fits them, and a plan. You will find all three in the first chapter. Everything after it shows you how to get accepted and stay paid.

1. **Minutes 0–15.** Read Chapter 1 and circle the 3–5 opportunities that match your profile.
2. **Minutes 15–45.** Run prompts P01–P03 (Chapter 9) on one real job posting to produce a tailored, ATS-readable resume.
3. **Minutes 45–75.** Open the application links and submit your first 2–3 applications. Start with the platforms marked Apply Now.
4. **Minutes 75–90.** Copy the 7-Day Urgent Income tracker from the Action Workbook and schedule tomorrow.

How to read the status labels

Every opportunity in this guide carries one of four labels. A platform earns Apply Now only when it has **both** a genuine, currently open application route for US residents **and** credible evidence that past workers were accepted and paid.

Label	What it means	What you should do
Apply Now	Open application route for US residents + documented worker outcomes (acceptance, payment, hiring).	Apply this week.
Explore	Real organization, but openings are listing-specific, narrow, invite-only, or evidence of worker outcomes is thin.	Check the live listing first. Apply if it fits you exactly.
Caution	Real organization with material risks: upfront costs, pay disputes, very low volume, legal complaints, or few remote openings.	Read the risk note before investing time or money.
Unavailable	Not accepting US sign-ups at verification.	Use the listed alternative.

Three facts to keep in mind

1. **Being accepted is not the same as being paid.** Many AI-training and freelance platforms accept you into a pool and then offer work only when projects open. Worker reports repeatedly describe “empty queues” and long silences after onboarding. Apply to several platforms at once.
2. **Historical success does not guarantee current availability.** Pay rates, projects, and openings change weekly. Every listing here shows its verification date (**October 22, 2026**). Check the live page before you rely on any number.
3. **Anecdotes are not promises.** This guide separates *official* facts (what a company publishes) from *individual* experiences (what one worker reported). Individual stories show what is possible and what tends to go wrong. They are not predictions of your result.

> **No legitimate employer or platform will ask you to pay to get a job, buy equipment from them, deposit a check and send money back, or move to WhatsApp or Telegram for "training."** If you see any of these, stop. Chapter 5 shows how to spot and report scams.

Who this playbook is for

- **Laid-off and unemployed professionals** who need income now and a stable role next. Your domain expertise is valuable to AI companies and expert networks today.
- **Undergraduates and fresh graduates** who need a first paid remote role, a portfolio, and a network. Graduate students have an additional, well-paid AI-training route (Handshake AI Fellowship).
- **Career switchers** who need to translate past experience into a new field, and prove it with small, real projects.

What this guide is not

It is not a get-rich-quick plan, and it will not promise you a job or a specific income. It does not cover relocation, MBA pathways, or general career theory. It covers specific places to apply, what they actually require, what real workers report, and the exact steps, prompts, and templates to move from reading to applying in one sitting.

Research method: Platforms, pay, eligibility, and application routes were checked through official pages, official job listings, and independent reporting between October 21 and 22, 2026. Worker experiences come from news reporting, review sites (Indeed, Glassdoor, Trustpilot), and community forums. Limits and unresolved items are listed in Appendix C and in `FACT_CHECK.md`.

CHAPTER 1

The Opportunity Directory: Where to Apply First

In this chapter: the 30 opportunities that currently pass both tests (open US application route + documented worker outcomes), ranked by situation, with direct links. The full directory has 71 entries across three categories, detailed in Chapters 2–4 and Appendix A.

Pick your lane in 60 seconds

Answer the first question that is true for you:

1. **"I need money in the next 1–2 weeks."** → Run three tracks at once. (a) Generalist AI training: DataAnnotation, Outlier, TELUS Digital, Prolific. (b) Paid research studies: UserTesting, Respondent, User Interviews. (c) One freelance service built on a skill you already have (Upwork/Fiverr). Expect small, irregular amounts first. Chapter 12 has the 7-day plan.
2. **"I have deep professional expertise (law, finance, medicine, engineering, software, teaching, writing, operations)."** → Expert AI training: Mercor, Alignerr, micro1, Turing, Snorkel. Add GLG for paid expert calls. Expert listings commonly pay $40–150/hr, but they are project-based and unpredictable.
3. **"I am a master's or PhD student or recent graduate in the US."** → Handshake AI Fellowship ($50–125/hr range, official FAQ) plus Mercor and Alignerr.
4. **"I am an undergraduate or new grad with little experience."** → DataAnnotation, Outlier, Prolific, TELUS for income; Handshake jobs, YC Work at a Startup, and Wellfound for a first career role; Apple At Home Advisor (College Program) and customer-service employers for a W-2 paycheck.
5. **"I want a stable, salaried remote job."** → Targeted applications on LinkedIn, Indeed, We Work Remotely, Remotive, and Wellfound, combined with referrals (Chapter 11). Plan for a 30–90 day process: the median time to a first offer in one 2025 dataset was 68.5 days.

The Apply Now list

All links were checked through search indexing on October 22, 2026. Pay is what the platform or listing published, or what the cited source reported. It is not a guarantee.

Platform	Category	Who it fits	Published pay (as reported)	First step
Mercor	A	Some (generalist and writing roles exist; best fit is proven domain experience)	Listings seen: Expert Model Trainer $50–140/hr; Concierge AI Trainer (US) $65–75/hr; Training & Development Specialist $60–110/hr (US/UK/CA, min 15 h/wk). BI reported a...	Create profile and upload resume

Platform	Category	Who it fits	Published pay (as reported)	First step
DataAnnotation	A	Yes (generalist track requires strong English writing and reasoning, no degree)	Generalist from ~$20+/hr; coding/specialist ~$40/hr and up (FAQ as quoted by multiple 2026 reviews; job board shows higher ranges for technical roles)	Apply on site
Outlier (Scale AI)	A	Yes for generalist projects (availability uneven)	Generalist listings advertise up to ~$15/hr; contributor-reported $12–30/hr standard work; expert pages advertise higher (e.g., up to $50/hr for some domains). Pay...	Create account
Alignerr (Labelbox)	A	Some (most listings want degrees or professional skill)	AI Trainer (PhD) $30–150/hr for US-based (official listing); homepage reportedly cites ~$80/hr average; listings vary widely	Apply to a listing
Handshake AI Fellowship (MOVE)	A	Yes for current/recent graduate students (master's/PhD) in any field	$50–125/hr by education and expertise (official EDU-partner FAQ); individual listings e.g. $75–100/hr math	Sign up at fellowship page
micro1	A	Some (generalist annotator listings; college-student listings seen)	Official portal: AI Trainer & Data Annotator $20–98/hr; Software Engineer AI Trainer $30–80/hr; Indeed average ~$67/hr across 13 postings	Browse opportunities portal
TELUS Digital AI Community	A	Yes	Content Reviewer – United States: est. $14/hr ($0.2333 per task), open to Nov 27, 2026; earlier US Rater listing $12–14/hr	Apply to country/language listing
Prolific	A	Yes	Researchers must pay at least $8/hr; Prolific recommends $12/hr (official). Self-reported totals ~$150–500/month for active users	Register
Turing	A	No (developers and domain experts)	Turing recruiting page: $50–250/hr; listings $25–55/hr (LLM trainer) to $200–300/hr (senior dev)	Profile
Y Combinator — Work at a Startup	A	Some (new grads and interns welcome at many startups)	Salary and equity shown per listing (e.g., Halluminate roles $150–275K)	Create one profile
Wellfound (formerly AngelList Talent)	A	Some	Salary and equity ranges on listings	Build profile
Upwork	B	Yes (slow start typical)	Freelancer sets rate. Fees: variable freelancer service fee 0–15% shown at proposal (third-party); Freelancer Plus $19.99/mo incl. 100 Connects and 0% service fee...	Sign up
Fiverr	B	Yes	Seller sets price; Fiverr keeps 20% of every order incl. tips	Create seller account
Contra	B	Yes (best for invoicing clients you find yourself)	0% commission for freelancers (official); Pro $29/mo or $199/yr (third-party)	Create profile
Toptal	B	No (senior talent)	Talent sets hourly rate; Toptal does not publish markup	Language & personality interview
Braintrust	B	No	Talent keeps 100% (official: no talent fees)	Create profile

Platform	Category	Who it fits	Published pay (as reported)	First step
Arc.dev	B	No	Reported $60–80/hr for freelancers (third-party)	Profile
GLG (Gerson Lehrman Group)	B	No (needs industry experience; laid-off professionals fit well)	You set/agree a per-call rate; advice sites estimate $100–300/hr typical	Create network member profile
Wyzant	C	Yes (subject mastery required)	Tutors set rates; commission 25% until $2,000 earned, then 20% (third-party)	Profile
Rev	C	Yes	~$0.30–1.10 per audio minute (third-party); effective hourly often low	Apply
UserTesting	C	Yes	~$10 per test; live interviews $30–60 (third-party)	Sign up
Respondent	C	Yes (professional background helps)	$50–400+ per study (third-party)	Profile
User Interviews	C	Yes	Per study (shown on listing)	Sign up
LinkedIn Jobs	C	Yes	Pay ranges shown on many US listings	Filter Remote + date posted (past 24h/week)
Indeed	C	Yes	Varies	Search ‘remote’ + title
We Work Remotely	C	Some	Varies	Filter region
Remotive	C	Some	Often listed	Filter
Himalayas	C	Some	Often listed	Filter by US
Handshake (student & new-grad jobs)	C	Yes	Varies	Log in via school
CareerOneStop / American Job Centers	C	Yes	Free services	Use Worker ReEmployment site

Category: A = AI training & AI startups · B = freelance & project marketplaces · C = other remote jobs. Click the platform name to open the application page.

Best first applications by situation

Your situation	Apply today	Apply this week	Why
Laid off, mid-career professional	Mercor (expert listing in your field), GLG	Alignerr, micro1, Turing (if technical), Wellfound, LinkedIn with referrals	Your expertise is the scarce input AI labs buy. Expert calls pay per hour of knowledge.
Unemployed, needs cash fast	DataAnnotation, Prolific, UserTesting	Outlier, TELUS Digital, Respondent, one Fiverr/Upwork service	Low barriers, real payouts, but irregular. Stack several.
Undergraduate / new grad	DataAnnotation, Handshake jobs	Outlier, Prolific, YC Work at a Startup, Apple At Home Advisor	Builds income and a work record while you pursue an entry-level role.

Your situation	Apply today	Apply this week	Why
Graduate student (US)	Handshake AI Fellowship	Mercor, Alignerr, Snorkel (if PhD/JD/MD)	Strongest documented pay band for academic expertise.
Career switcher	Upwork/Contra profile with 2–3 sample projects	LinkedIn outreach to people in target role, Wellfound	Proof of skill plus warm introductions matter more than titles.
Software developer	Turing, Mercor coding listings, DataAnnotation coding track	Toptal, Arc.dev, Braintrust, YC Work at a Startup	Coding evaluation pays well above generalist AI work.
Customer service background	Amazon/Apple/Concentrix/TTEC listings in your state	Wyzant (if you can tutor), BELAY (if admin), LinkedIn	W-2 roles with steady hours and benefits beat per-minute contractor models.

What “realistic” looks like

The research behind this playbook points to these planning numbers. They come from documented sources, and individual results vary widely:

- **AI-training acceptance:** typically days to about four weeks after an assessment. Rejection is often silent (DataAnnotation, Mercor, TELUS).
- **First freelance client:** documented cases range from 6 days to 6 months. “About 2 months” is a common report on the Upwork Community forum.
- **First Fiverr order:** worker reports range from about one week to several weeks, and some sellers get none.
- **Salaried remote job:** a median of 68.5 days to first offer across 461,000 tracked applications (Huntr, Q2 2025). Remote postings were 8.4% of LinkedIn jobs but drew 42% of applications.

Because no single channel is reliable, the action plan in Chapter 12 runs **income tracks and career tracks at the same time.**

Do this now: Choose 3 Apply Now platforms from the table above that fit your lane.

Then: Open each application link in a new tab and create your accounts before reading further. Account creation and ID verification often take a day to clear.

Remember: Being accepted ≠ having paid work. Apply in parallel.

CHAPTER 2

AI Training & AI Startups

> **In this chapter:** what AI-training work actually involves, the full category table, and detailed profiles of the platforms with the strongest evidence. AI companies pay people to write, judge, and correct model outputs. Generalist work is accessible but unstable. Expert work pays more and is in higher demand.

What the work actually is

"AI training," "RLHF," "data annotation," and "AI tutoring" all describe the same core activity: humans producing the examples and judgments that teach AI models. Typical tasks:

Task type	What you do	Who it suits	Typical pay signal*
Response rating / comparison (RLHF)	Read a prompt and two AI answers, pick the better one, explain why against a rubric	Careful readers and writers	$15–30/hr generalist
Prompt writing & ideal responses	Write challenging prompts and model answers that meet strict constraints	Strong writers	$20–40/hr
Fact-checking / red-teaming	Find errors, unsafe advice, or policy violations in AI output	Researchers, analysts, editors	$20–50/hr
Domain expert evaluation	Judge answers in law, medicine, finance, STEM; write graduate-level problems	Professionals, grad students	$40–150/hr
Coding evaluation	Review, debug, and write code; compare AI code solutions	Developers	$40–150+/hr
Search/ads/content rating	Rate search results or content against long guidelines	Detail-oriented beginners	$12–16/hr
Audio/data collection	Record speech, label images or video	Anyone with equipment	Per task, varies

Ranges are drawn from the listings and reports cited in this chapter. Your rate is set per project.

What all of them reward: following instructions precisely, writing clearly, reasoning visibly, and consistent quality. **What gets people removed:** using AI tools to do the tasks, rushing, ignoring guidelines, and inconsistent quality scores.

The full category table

Platform	Status	Roles & tasks	Beginner?	Published pay	Evidence
Mercor	Apply Now	Hourly contracts writing, grading and red-teaming AI outputs in a domain (law, finance, medicine, STEM, software,...	Some (generalist and writing roles...	Listings seen: Expert Model Trainer $50–140/hr; Concierge AI Trainer (US) $65–75/hr; Training & Development Specialist $60–110/hr (US/UK/CA, min 15 h/wk). BI reported a...	Strong
DataAnnotation	Apply Now	Write prompts, compare and rate chatbot answers, fact-check, coding evaluation, specialist (math, science, law) tracks	Yes (generalist track requires strong...	Generalist from ~$20+/hr; coding/specialist ~$40/hr and up (FAQ as quoted by multiple 2026 reviews; job board shows higher ranges for technical roles)	Strong
Outlier (Scale AI)	Apply Now	Generalist writing/rating, domain expert tasks (STEM, medicine, law, coding), multilingual and audio projects	Yes for generalist projects...	Generalist listings advertise up to ~$15/hr; contributor-reported $12–30/hr standard work; expert pages advertise higher (e.g., up to $50/hr for some domains). Pay...	Strong
Alignerr (Labelbox)	Apply Now	Domain-expert AI training (STEM, coding in many languages, writing), human preference ranking, code evaluation	Some (most listings want degrees or...	AI Trainer (PhD) $30–150/hr for US-based (official listing); homepage reportedly cites ~$80/hr average; listings vary widely	Medium
Handshake AI Fellowship (MOVE)	Apply Now	Expert prompts, evaluation and reasoning tasks for frontier AI labs by academic field	Yes for current/recent graduate...	$50–125/hr by education and expertise (official EDU-partner FAQ); individual listings e.g. $75–100/hr math	Medium
micro1	Apply Now	AI trainer & data annotator, software engineer AI trainer, domain experts, some full-time placements	Some (generalist annotator listings;...	Official portal: AI Trainer & Data Annotator $20–98/hr; Software Engineer AI Trainer $30–80/hr; Indeed average ~$67/hr across 13 postings	Medium
TELUS Digital AI Community	Apply Now	Content reviewer, search/map rater, data collection and annotation, AI response assessment	Yes	Content Reviewer – United States: est. $14/hr ($0.2333 per task), open to Nov 27, 2026; earlier US Rater listing $12–14/hr	Medium
Prolific	Apply Now	Surveys, experiments, AI evaluation studies, some specialist AI tasker pools	Yes	Researchers must pay at least $8/hr; Prolific recommends $12/hr (official). Self-reported totals ~$150–500/month for active users	Strong
Turing	Apply Now	LLM coding evaluation (Python, JS, C++ and more), agent/function-call training, domain expert tasks	No (developers and domain experts)	Turing recruiting page: $50–250/hr; listings $25–55/hr (LLM trainer) to $200–300/hr (senior dev)	Medium
Invisible Technologies (Expert Marketplace / Meridial)	Explore	Freelance AI trainers by domain (writing, Python, finance, law, instructional design)	Some	Listings: $8–65/hr by experience/location; specialist roles up to $150–200/hr (pay guide of ~800 listings)	Weak

Platform	Status	Roles & tasks	Beginner?	Published pay	Evidence
Snorkel AI Expert Community	Explore	Expert contributors in law, medicine, STEM, computer science write and grade tasks	No (advanced degrees common)	$10–100 per high-quality task (law listing); $10–80 per submission (2025 listing)	Weak
xAI — AI Tutor	Explore	Full-time temporary AI tutor roles (STEM, bilingual, specialist)	Some (specialists now preferred)	$35–65/hr in listings	Medium
Mindrift (Toloka)	Explore	AI trainer writers, STEM/code specialists, journalists, designers	Some (≥1 year professional experience,...	Advertised $15–100+/hr; typical generalist $15–30/hr; listing example $55/hr STEM	Medium
Welo Data (Welocalize)	Explore	Search quality rater, ads rater, translation validation	Yes	Scout Search Quality Rater – English (US): $14.50/hr, W-2 part-time, paid every 2 weeks, 12-month project (Apr 2026 listing)	Medium
RWS TrainAI	Explore	Search engine evaluator, AI data annotator, speech evaluation	Yes	US Search Engine Evaluator listing 'up to $15.8/hr' (Oct 2, 2026); blogs report $15–22/hr	Weak
Appen (CrowdGen)	Caution	Search/social evaluation, annotation, data collection	Yes	Not published centrally; reviews cite $10–20/hr industry averages	Medium
OneForma (Centific)	Caution	Annotation, transcription, data collection	Yes	Reported $7–13/hr equivalent; transcription $0.50–1.25 per audio minute	Medium
Clickworker / UHRS	Explore	Microtasks: categorization, short writing, UHRS search judging	Yes	Effective $2–9/hr typical (third-party)	Medium
Remotasks	Unavailable	Legacy annotation platform; new sign-ups redirected to Outlier in tests	n/a	n/a	Medium
Uber AI Solutions	Explore	Coding validation, audio recording, image/video labeling; US driver pilot for in-app tasks	Yes (pilot-based)	Not verified ($20–200/hr claim from a weak source)	Weak
Y Combinator — Work at a Startup	Apply Now	Engineering, design, product, operations, sales, recruiting at YC-funded startups; remote filter available	Some (new grads and interns welcome at...	Salary and equity shown per listing (e.g., Halluminate roles $150–275K)	Medium
Wellfound (formerly AngelList Talent)	Apply Now	Startup roles across functions; remote filters; salary/equity shown before applying	Some	Salary and equity ranges on listings	Medium
Halluminate (YC S25)	Explore	Full-time SF roles; company recruits and trains 'contractor finance staff' (no public contractor application found)	No	$150–275K full-time (YC listings)	Weak

23 entries. Click a platform name to open its application page. Full profiles (steps, payment, evidence, challenges, strategies, sources) are in Appendix A.

Platform profiles

Mercor: Apply Now (expert hourly contracts)

Who it fits: professionals with demonstrable domain experience. Mercor listings span law, finance, medicine, engineering, software, writing, audio, and operations. Listings seen in October 2026 included an *Expert Model Trainer* at $50–140/hr and a US *Concierge – AI Trainer* at $65–75/hr.

How you get in. Upload your resume and complete a roughly 20-minute AI video interview generated from it. Mercor's official guide says you can take a practice interview, redo the AI interview before submitting, and reuse a completed interview for other listings. Some roles add an assessment or a human call.

Evidence. Indeed reviewers consistently praise weekly pay. News reports put Mercor's 2025 contractor hiring above 30,000. The other side: reviewers report waits of "2 weeks to 6 months," and Business Insider documented contractors whose project ended being offered a similar one at $16/hr. Mercor disputed that report.

Strategy. Apply to the narrowest listing that matches your verifiable expertise rather than a generic pool. Before the interview, rehearse a 60-second deep-dive on each major project on your resume, covering what you did, how, and the result, because the AI interviewer probes resume content.

DataAnnotation: Apply Now (best documented generalist entry)

Who it fits: strong English writers who reason carefully. No degree is required for the generalist track, and coding and specialist tracks pay more. Reported eligibility: US, UK, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand.

How you get in. One Starter Assessment of about an hour. It is unpaid and **you cannot retake it.** Then you wait, often 1–4 weeks, and if you do not pass you may hear nothing. Once accepted, you take paid qualification tests that unlock projects on your dashboard.

Evidence. It is rated 4.1/5 on both Indeed (1,477 reviews, June 2026) and Glassdoor, with reviewers saying "payment is prompt and problem free." Community FAQs report hourly work becoming payable about 7 days after submission. Negatives include silent rejection, project dry spells, and abrupt account closures. A pending California class action alleges contractor misclassification; these are allegations only.

Strategy. Take the assessment rested and undistracted. Write complete, organized answers: state your choice, give the reasons, and cite specifics. **Never use an AI assistant to write your answers.** After acceptance, complete every qualification offered, since each one widens your project pool.

Outlier (Scale AI): Apply Now (high volume, high variance)

How you get in. Outlier's official onboarding takes 30–90 minutes: account, expertise selection, skill screening, and ID verification. Then each project has its own qualifiers. Onboarding and qualifiers are unpaid. Payments are processed weekly on Tuesdays via PayPal, AirTM, or ACH.

Evidence. It is rated 3.2/5 on Glassdoor. Business Insider reported a generalist whose rate fell "from $50 to $15" an hour. The most common complaint across 2026 reviews is the *empty queue*: being onboarded with no tasks available. A June 2026 reviewer warned of deactivation "based on opaque automated flags."

Strategy. Treat Outlier as one stream among several, not a job. If you hold a degree in a specialist area, register for those expert pages, where pay and stability are better. Make sure your PayPal name and email match your Outlier profile to avoid first-payout holds.

Alignerr (Labelbox): Apply Now (experts; keep records)

The official Greenhouse listing for *AI Trainer (PhD)* shows **$30–150/hr for US-based** candidates. Many roles use an AI interviewer ("Zara"). Trustpilot contributors praise how specific the interview is to their resume, and others report unpaid removal after about 6 hours of work and disputed payments. **Strategy:** apply only where your degree or skill matches exactly. Log hours and task IDs, and stop after the first payment cycle that does not clear.

Handshake AI Fellowship: Apply Now (US graduate students)

Handshake's official FAQ for university partners gives **$50–125/hr** based on education and expertise. Cornell's graduate school promotes it to **US-based master's and doctoral students, candidates, and graduates in all fields.** The process: sign up at the fellowship page, upload your resume, verify ID, wait for rolling review and matching, complete a **paid** training exercise, then join a project. Handshake states that applying does not guarantee a project and that projects can pause on short notice. **Strategy:** ask your career office about it, and list your thesis topic, methods, and sub-field precisely so you match more projects.

micro1: Apply Now

The official portal (jobs.micro1.ai) lists roles such as *AI Trainer & Data Annotator* at **$20–98/hr** and *Software Engineer – AI Trainer* at $30–80/hr. You complete a skill interview with micro1's AI interviewer and an ID check. It is rated 4.8/5 from 130 Indeed reviews. A Glassdoor reviewer reported being offered a low-rate generic contract. **Strategy:** apply to a specific listing, and confirm the rate and what time is billable before you start.

TELUS Digital AI Community: Apply Now (beginner-friendly rating)

US *Content Reviewer* listings show an estimated **$14/hr** ($0.2333 per task) as an independent contractor, one person per household. You must pass an unpaid qualification exam on long guidelines. TELUS states that it never asks candidates for deposits or "Premium ID" fees, and fake recruiters using its name do. **Strategy:** study the guidelines like a certification exam.

Prolific: Apply Now (studies, small but reliable)

Prolific enforces a minimum of **$8/hr** and recommends $12/hr for studies. The US is supported, though new participants may be waitlisted. Community earnings logs from late 2025 show roughly $150–500 a month for active users. **Strategy:** complete your "About You" screeners fully and honestly, because they determine which studies you see.

Turing: Apply Now (developers and experts)

Turing's US recruiting page advertises **$50–250/hr** projects at 10–20 hrs/week for US-based developers. Vetting includes automated coding tests, an AI interview, and skill assessments. Payment is monthly via Deel, Payoneer, or bank transfer.

AI startups: YC Work at a Startup and Wellfound (Apply Now)

AI training is not the only way into AI. **YC Work at a Startup** uses one profile that YC-funded founders can browse, and you can also apply directly. **Wellfound** shows salary and equity ranges before you apply and states each startup's "hires remotely from" locations. For new grads and career switchers, these sites lead to real

operations, support, sales, and engineering jobs at growing AI companies. Example: **Halluminate** (YC S25) lists full-time San Francisco roles at $150–275K with a paid work-trial process. It recruits contractor finance staff, but has no public contractor application, so it is labeled Explore.

The honest risk picture

- **Generalist work is shrinking relative to expert work.** xAI laid off at least 500 generalist AI tutors in September 2025 while announcing a 10x expansion of specialist tutors. Outlier reviews describe the same shift.
- **Rates move.** Project rates are set per project and can change between projects.
- **You are a 1099 contractor** on nearly all of these platforms. There is no tax withholding and no benefits. Set aside roughly 25–30% for federal and state taxes, and confirm with a tax professional or IRS guidance.
- **AI use is prohibited** on tasks. Contractors have been removed for using AI tools, Grammarly, or AI translation.

Fastest legitimate start: DataAnnotation + Outlier + Prolific + TELUS (generalist), or Mercor + Alignerr + micro1 (expert).

Highest documented pay: domain-expert listings (Mercor, Alignerr, Handshake for grad students, Turing for developers).

Biggest risk: waiting on one platform. Apply to at least three.

CHAPTER 3

Freelance & Project Marketplaces

In this chapter: where to sell skills you already have, what each marketplace costs you in fees, and what first-client timelines really look like. Upwork and Fiverr have the most buyers and the most competition. Vetted networks (Toptal, Braintrust, Arc) pay better but suit experienced people. Expert networks (GLG and peers) pay per hour of industry knowledge.

The category table

Platform	Status	Roles & tasks	Beginner?	Fees / payment	Evidence
Upwork	Apply Now	Bid on client jobs or sell Project Catalog packages: writing, design, admin/VA, marketing, data, development, AI...	Yes (slow start typical)	Basic: 10 free Connects/mo, extra $0.15 each; withdraw to US bank	Strong
Fiverr	Apply Now	Sell fixed-scope gigs: design, writing, video, voice, data, AI services, VA	Yes	Earnings clear after ~14 days (7 for Top Rated); withdrawal fees vary	Medium
Contra	Apply Now	Portfolio + service listings for design, development, marketing, content; invoices and contracts for clients you bring	Yes (best for invoicing clients you...	Bank, card, PayPal, USDC payouts; clients may pay fees	Weak
Freelancer.com	Explore	Bid on projects; contests for design	Yes (very price-competitive)	Membership tiers add bids	Weak
Toptal	Apply Now	Developers, designers, finance experts, project/product managers on client engagements	No (senior talent)	No fee to talent	Medium
Braintrust	Apply Now	Contract roles in engineering, design, product, marketing at enterprise clients	No	Free to talent	Weak
Guru	Explore	Programming, writing, design, admin, engineering	Yes	SafePay escrow	Weak
PeoplePerHour	Explore	Hourlies (fixed offers) and proposals	Yes	GBP-centric	Weak
99designs (Vista)	Explore	Logo, branding, packaging, web design contests and direct projects	Yes (contests)	Level-based fees	Medium
Arc.dev	Apply Now	Freelance and full-time remote developer roles	No	Free to developers	Weak
MarketerHire	Explore	Paid media, growth, content, lifecycle, SEO contracts	No	Not published	Weak

Platform	Status	Roles & tasks	Beginner?	Fees / payment	Evidence
Catalant	Explore	Strategy, operations, finance consulting projects for enterprises	No	Not published	Weak
GLG (Gerson Lehrman Group)	Apply Now	Paid 1-hour phone/video consultations with investors and consultants about your industry knowledge	No (needs industry experience; laid-off...	Paid per consultation	Medium
AlphaSights / Guidepoint	Explore	Paid expert calls and surveys	No	Per consultation	Medium
Dribbble / Behance	Explore	Portfolio hosting, freelance project inquiries, job boards	Yes	Platform payment fees vary by plan	Weak

15 entries. Click a platform name to open its application page. Full profiles (steps, payment, evidence, challenges, strategies, sources) are in Appendix A.

Choosing your marketplace

If you...	Start on	Add later	Why
Have a clear service and want to bid on posted jobs	**Upwork**	Contra (for direct clients)	Largest US client base for project work; proposals let you tailor every pitch.
Prefer selling a fixed package	**Fiverr**	Upwork Project Catalog	Buyers come to you; works best for narrowly defined deliverables.
Already have contacts or an audience	**Contra**	LinkedIn Services	0% freelancer commission; professional invoices and contracts.
Have 3+ years in software, design, finance, or product	**Toptal**, **Braintrust**, **Arc.dev**	MarketerHire (marketing), Catalant (consulting)	Higher rates; harder vetting.
Are a laid-off industry professional	**GLG**, Guidepoint, AlphaSights	Catalant	Paid by the call for knowledge you already hold.
Are a designer	**99designs** contests sparingly, **Dribbble/Behance** portfolio	Upwork	Portfolio quality drives inbound leads.

What it really costs: fees at a glance

Platform	You pay	Notes
Upwork	Variable service fee 0–15% (shown when you submit a proposal); Connects to bid (10 free per month on Basic, extra Connects $0.15 each)	Freelancer Plus ($19.99/month) includes 100 Connects and 0% freelancer service fee per Upwork's pricing page. Run the numbers before you subscribe.
Fiverr	20% of every order, including tips	Earnings clear after about 14 days (7 for Top Rated).

Platform	You pay	Notes
Contra	0% commission	Clients may pay fees. Pro plan reported at $29/month.
Freelancer.com	10% or $5 minimum per project payment	Limited free bids.
Toptal / Braintrust	No talent fee	Client pays the platform.
Guru	~5–9% by plan	
PeoplePerHour	20% of first £500 with each client, then lower tiers	UK-centric clients.

Fees are reported as of October 2026 from official pricing pages where available and third-party fee guides otherwise. Check the live pricing page before you commit money.

Platform profiles

Upwork: Apply Now

How it works. Create a profile, get approved, and spend Connects to submit proposals on client job posts. You can also sell fixed packages in the Project Catalog. Contracts run as fixed-price milestones (escrow-protected) or hourly with the work-diary tracker.

Evidence of outcomes. Upwork Community members report "about 2 months to land my first client, and 3 weeks after that to land my next." Others sent proposals "for 6 months" before a first job, and several turned things around only after changing their profile and niche. Upwork's own collection of Reddit stories quotes a freelancer who made a profile in July and landed a first client in October. A self-reported case describes a 22-year-old barista with no freelance history hired six days after his first proposals. The author sells a course, so treat it as possible, not typical. A moderator notes that identity verification often comes *after* the first contract, so don't wait for it.

What separates winners (pattern across reports): (1) a niche title instead of "virtual assistant / writer / designer"; (2) 2–3 portfolio samples that look like the client's problem; (3) applying within hours of a post; (4) short, specific proposals whose first line restates the client's goal; (5) small first jobs to earn reviews. Chapter 8 covers each step.

Fiverr: Apply Now

You publish "gigs": packaged services with three price tiers. Fiverr keeps **20%** of every order. Fiverr Community posts show first orders arriving after about **three weeks** for some sellers, and immediate repeat orders when the first buyer is delighted. Others got one quick order and then nothing for three months. Fiverr alone is unreliable, so pair it with outreach.

Gig formula that tends to work: *[Outcome] for [specific buyer] in [timeframe]*, for example "I will set up a Notion client CRM for real-estate agents in 48 hours," rather than "I will do Notion."

Contra: Apply Now (as your portfolio and payment rail)

Contra charges freelancers **0% commission**. Its job board is thin for free users, so use Contra mainly to host a clean portfolio, send proposals and invoices, and get paid by clients you find on LinkedIn or through referrals.

Toptal, Braintrust, Arc.dev: Apply Now (experienced talent)

Toptal says it accepts fewer than 3% of applicants. Its screening runs from a language and communication interview to a timed skill test, a live screening, and a 1–3 week test project, totaling 3–8 weeks. **Braintrust** charges talent no fee and screens with an AI interviewer (AIR). **Arc.dev** focuses on remote developers for freelance and full-time roles. Apply to these only if you have several years of strong, demonstrable work.

GLG and expert networks: Apply Now (laid-off professionals)

Expert networks pay you per call, usually one hour, to share industry knowledge with investors and consultants. Advice sites estimate typical rates of **$100–300/hr**, higher for senior specialists. Invitations are irregular. Strict compliance rules apply: you may not share confidential information from a current or former employer. **Strategy:** make your profile and LinkedIn headline name the niche you know ("Medicare Advantage claims operations," "industrial HVAC distribution," "B2B payments compliance"). Networks search for those exact terms.

Freelance services you can sell this week

These require skills many readers already have. The "Proof" column is what to put in your portfolio before the first proposal.

Service	Typical clients	Proof to create (2–4 hours)
Inbox, calendar & admin support	Solo founders, coaches, realtors	A one-page SOP + sample inbox triage rules
Customer support (email/chat)	Shopify stores, SaaS startups	5 sample macros/replies for a real store's FAQ
Data entry & spreadsheet cleanup	Small businesses	Before/after Google Sheet with formulas
Research & lead lists	B2B sales teams	25-row sample lead list with sourcing notes
AI workflow setup (ChatGPT/Claude custom instructions, Zapier/Make)	Small teams	Loom video of an automation you built
Writing & editing	Blogs, newsletters, LinkedIn ghostwriting	2 sample articles in the client's niche
Bookkeeping cleanup (if qualified)	Small businesses	Redacted reconciliation checklist
Tutoring & test prep	Students, parents	Sample lesson plan
Resume & LinkedIn rewrites	Job seekers	Before/after (with permission or your own)
Basic web/landing pages	Local businesses	One live demo site

Rule of thumb: one niche, one marketplace, two proposals a day, for at least three weeks, before judging results.

Fees matter: price so that you still hit your target hourly rate *after* platform fees and about 25–30% set aside for taxes (prompt P13).

Never accept payment or communication off-platform before a contract exists. It is the most common route to freelance scams.

CHAPTER 4

Other Remote Jobs: Employers, Gigs & Job Boards

In this chapter: remote W-2 employers that hire beginners (customer service, tech support), virtual assistance, tutoring, transcription, testing and paid research, the job boards worth your time, and free public help for laid-off workers. W-2 employee roles give steadier hours, tax withholding and often benefits. Per-minute and per-task contractor roles usually do not.

The category table

Platform	Status	Roles & tasks	Beginner?	Published pay	Evidence
Amazon — Virtual Customer Service	Explore	Chat/phone customer service from home; seasonal and regular	Yes	~$15–19/hr reported; ZipRecruiter aggregate avg $18.80/hr	Medium
Apple — At Home Advisor	Explore	AppleCare phone/chat support; College Program variant for students	Yes	College Program At Home Advisor $27.75–32.45/hr (tech.co); ZipRecruiter aggregate avg $26.41 (Aug 2026)	Medium
Concentrix (work-at-home)	Explore	Customer service, tech support, sales for client brands	Yes	~$13–18/hr reported (2026)	Medium
TTEC @Home	Explore	Customer care, tech support, sales	Yes	~$15–18/hr reported; some reduced training rate	Medium
Foundever (formerly Sitel)	Explore	Customer service and support	Yes	~$14–17/hr reported	Medium
Liveops	Caution	Inbound calls for client programs (insurance, healthcare, retail)	Some	Talk-time 25–34¢ per minute for some programs; some commission-only (official FAQ)	Medium
Arise	Caution	Customer service for client brands as an independent business	Some	Not published	Strong
Working Solutions	Explore	Customer support, sales, tech support programs	Some	Not verified (~$15/hr listicle)	Weak
BELAY	Explore	Executive/virtual assistant, bookkeeping, web specialist for US small businesses	No (admin experience expected)	Clients pay ~$42–50/hr; VA pay ~$20/hr in one anonymous report; BELAY says it raised specialist pay ≥53% in four years	Medium
Wyzant	Apply Now	1-on-1 tutoring in academic subjects, test prep, professional skills	Yes (subject mastery required)	Tutors set rates; commission 25% until $2,000 earned, then 20% (third-party)	Medium
Varsity Tutors	Explore	Tutoring matched by algorithm	Yes	$15–40/hr; ~$15 most common (third-party)	Medium

Platform	Status	Roles & tasks	Beginner?	Published pay	Evidence
Tutor.com (Princeton Review)	Explore	On-demand chat tutoring	Yes	$12–22/hr reported	Weak
Rev	Apply Now	Transcription, captions, subtitles	Yes	~$0.30–1.10 per audio minute (third-party); effective hourly often low	Medium
TranscribeMe	Explore	Short-clip transcription	Yes	$15–22 per audio hour (third-party)	Weak
GoTranscript	Explore	Transcription	Yes	Up to $0.60 per audio minute (third-party)	Weak
UserTesting	Apply Now	Think-aloud tests (~$10 for 15–20 min), live interviews ($30–60)	Yes	~$10 per test; live interviews $30–60 (third-party)	Medium
Respondent	Apply Now	Paid user-research interviews, focus groups	Yes (professional background helps)	$50–400+ per study (third-party)	Medium
User Interviews	Apply Now	Interviews, surveys, usability studies	Yes	Per study (shown on listing)	Medium
uTest (Applause)	Explore	Functional/usability testing; pay per approved bug	Yes	Per bug/cycle; $5–50 per cycle commonly reported	Medium
Testlio	Explore	Hourly software testing on client projects	Some	Hourly; e.g., $18/hr listing (2025)	Medium
LinkedIn Jobs	Apply Now	All functions; ‘Remote’ workplace filter (f_WT=2)	Yes	Pay ranges shown on many US listings	Strong
Indeed	Apply Now	All functions incl. remote customer service, admin, sales	Yes	Varies	Medium
We Work Remotely	Apply Now	Programming, design, customer support, sales, marketing, management	Some	Varies	Medium
Remotive	Apply Now	Tech, support, marketing, AI training listings	Some	Often listed	Medium
Himalayas	Apply Now	Remote roles with company profiles	Some	Often listed	Weak
Remote OK	Explore	Remote tech and non-tech roles	Some	Often listed	Weak
Working Nomads	Explore	Curated remote jobs	Some	Varies	Weak
Dynamite Jobs	Explore	Remote roles at bootstrapped companies (ops, VA, marketing)	Some	Salary shown on listings	Weak
Built In	Explore	Tech company roles incl. remote; carries AI training listings	Some	Often listed	Weak
Handshake (student & new-grad jobs)	Apply Now	Internships, entry-level remote roles, virtual career fairs	Yes	Varies	Medium

Platform	Status	Roles & tasks	Beginner?	Published pay	Evidence
FlexJobs	Caution	Screened remote/flexible listings	Yes	Subscription: $2.95 14-day trial auto-renewing ~$23.95/4 weeks; quarterly ~$29.85; annual ~$71.40 (third-party, varies)	Medium
USAJOBS (federal)	Caution	Federal roles; remote now rare	Some	GS pay scales on listings	Strong
CareerOneStop / American Job Centers	Apply Now	Unemployment insurance finder, ~2,300 local American Job Centers, resume help, training funds, state job banks	Yes	Free services	Strong

33 entries. Click a platform name to open its application page. Full profiles (steps, payment, evidence, challenges, strategies, sources) are in Appendix A.

W-2 employer or contractor? Know the difference

	W-2 employee (e.g., Amazon, Apple, Concentrix, TTEC, Welo Data's US Scout rater)	1099 contractor (e.g., Liveops, most AI-training and gig platforms)
Taxes	Withheld by employer	You pay income tax plus ~15.3% self-employment tax; make quarterly estimates
Minimum wage & overtime	Protected	Generally not
Benefits	Often (after a waiting period)	No
Equipment	Often provided	You buy it
Pay	Hourly for scheduled time	Per minute, per task, or per hour actually worked
Upfront costs	Should be **none**	Background check or training fees sometimes required (Liveops: $25 check). Never pay to "buy a job."

Customer service & tech support

These are the most accessible remote W-2 jobs for beginners. Reported 2026 pay: **Concentrix ~$13–18/hr, Foundever ~$14–17/hr, TTEC ~$15–18/hr, Amazon Virtual Customer Service ~$15–19/hr, Apple At Home Advisor** (College Program listing $27.75–32.45/hr). Common requirements: a quiet, private workspace, a wired high-speed connection (many run a speed test before the offer), a background check, and **residency in a state where the employer is hiring.**

How to apply safely: apply only on the employer's own careers site (amazon.jobs, jobs.apple.com, jobs.concentrix.com, careers.ttec.com, foundever.com/careers). Scammers impersonate these brands through text messages, WhatsApp, and fake listings.

Caution: contractor call-center models. *Liveops* is a real, long-running company. Its official FAQ says agents pay a **$25 background check**, certification is unpaid, and some programs pay **25–34¢ per talk-minute**, so you are paid only while on calls, with no guaranteed earnings. *Arise* was the subject of a ProPublica investigation and

a lawsuit by the D.C. Attorney General alleging that agents paid for training and equipment and were misclassified. Compute your real hourly rate before paying anything, and prefer W-2 roles.

Virtual assistance

BELAY places US-based contractors with small businesses. Clients reportedly pay $42–50/hr; one anonymous report put VA pay near $20/hr; BELAY says it raised specialist pay at least 53% over four years. It expects real admin experience. Many VAs build their own client base through Upwork, Contra, and LinkedIn instead. Prompt P09 builds that profile.

Tutoring

- **Wyzant** (Apply Now): you set your rate. Commission is reported at 25% until you earn $2,000, then 20%. You compete on profile and response speed.
- **Varsity Tutors** and **Tutor.com**: assigned sessions, lower pay (~$12–40/hr reported, with the low end most common), but no marketing needed.
- **Best practice:** start on a marketplace to get reviews, then offer private sessions to repeat students where the platform's terms allow it.

Transcription

Rev (Apply Now) requires a grammar test and a transcription sample. Reported pay is about **$0.30–1.10 per audio minute**, which often works out to a low hourly rate once editing time is counted. TranscribeMe and GoTranscript are similar. AI transcription has reduced demand. Use transcription for short-term cash, not as a career.

Testing & paid research studies

Platform	What you do	Reported pay
UserTesting	Think-aloud website/app tests; occasional live interviews	~$10 per 15–20 min test; $30–60 live
Respondent	Paid interviews for professionals	$50–400+ per study
User Interviews	Interviews, surveys, usability studies	Shown on each study
uTest (Applause)	Find bugs; paid per approved bug	Varies; high competition
Testlio	Hourly QA on client projects (paid trial cycle)	e.g., $18/hr listing

These pay quickly and need no experience, but volume is unpredictable. Testers report that $10 tests disappear within minutes, so turn on notifications.

Job boards worth your time

Board	Best for	Cost to you
LinkedIn Jobs (Remote filter)	All functions; recruiter outreach	Free
Indeed	Customer service, admin, sales, healthcare admin	Free
We Work Remotely	Tech, support, marketing (has "USA only" region filter)	Free
Remotive	Tech, support, AI-training listings	Free
Himalayas	Remote roles with company profiles	Free
Wellfound	Startups; salary and equity shown	Free
YC Work at a Startup	YC-backed startups	Free
Handshake	Students and recent grads	Free
Remote OK, Working Nomads, Dynamite Jobs, Built In	Supplementary listings	Free
FlexJobs (Caution)	Hand-screened listings	$2.95 trial that auto-renews (~$23.95 every 4 weeks reported)
USAJOBS (Caution)	Federal roles	Free, but the January 2025 executive order ended most federal remote work

Board strategy. Remote postings attract a disproportionate share of applicants: 8.4% of LinkedIn postings drew 42% of applications. Use the "past 24 hours" filter, apply early, then contact someone on the hiring team (Chapter 11). A posting that is two weeks old has usually received hundreds of applications.

Free public help for laid-off workers

- **Unemployment insurance:** file in the state where you worked, as soon as possible after a layoff. Use CareerOneStop's Unemployment Insurance finder to reach your state's site. Ask your state how part-time or 1099 earnings affect your weekly benefit, and report earnings exactly as required.
- **American Job Centers (~2,300 nationwide):** free career counseling, resume reviews, workshops, and access to training funds (WIOA). Many offer free premium learning platforms. Find yours at careeronestop.org.
- **Your university career office** (students and alumni): free resume reviews, mock interviews (often Big Interview or Yoodli access), and job boards. Many alumni do not know they can still use these services.

Steady paycheck fastest: a W-2 customer-service or tech-support role in your state, applied for on the employer's own site.

Money this week: UserTesting, Prolific, Respondent, and Rev, while longer applications are pending.

If laid off: file for unemployment and book an American Job Center appointment *today*. Both are free.

CHAPTER 5

Scams, Payment Risks & Protecting Yourself

> **In this chapter:** how remote-job and "task" scams work in 2026, a red-flag checklist, the payment and contractor risks on legitimate platforms, and where to report fraud. Job scams are growing fast, and remote seekers are the main target.

The scale of the problem

The Federal Trade Commission reported in December 2024 that **"task scams"** grew from essentially zero reports in 2020 to about 5,000 in 2023 and roughly **20,000 in the first half of 2024 alone.** Reported job-scam losses exceeded **$220 million** in those six months, and cryptocurrency losses to job scams nearly doubled. OpenAI's February 2025 threat report described a network using fake "recruiter" and "mentor" personas that steered victims to Telegram "training" before asking them to pay in. In July 2026 TELUS warned about AI-generated recruiter profiles and deepfake interviews.

How the common scams work

Scam	How it looks	The tell
Task / "optimization" scam	Unsolicited text or WhatsApp: "Earn $300/day rating apps or liking videos." Small early payouts build trust, then you must "deposit" to unlock bigger tasks.	You are asked to pay or deposit crypto to get paid.
Fake recruiter	LinkedIn or email from a "recruiter" at a real brand (Amazon, TELUS, Mercor); a chat-only interview; an instant offer.	The interview happens only by chat, the email domain is not the company's, and the offer comes before any real screening.
Equipment check scam	"We'll send you a check to buy your laptop from our approved vendor."	The check bounces after you've paid the "vendor."
Training fee / "Premium ID"	"Pay $49 for certification to join the AI project."	Legitimate AI-training platforms never charge to join. TELUS and Mindrift say so explicitly.
Off-platform freelance client	"Let's move to Telegram; I'll pay you via crypto/Zelle after delivery."	Moving off-platform before a contract exists removes payment protection.
Fake job board / application portal	A copy of a real company site asks for your SSN and bank details "for onboarding."	Legitimate employers collect I-9 and W-4 or direct-deposit details only *after* a real offer, through an official HR system.

Red-flag checklist

Stop if **any** of these is true:

- ☐ You must pay anything to be hired, trained, verified, or to "unlock" earnings.
- ☐ You were contacted out of the blue by text, WhatsApp, Telegram, or Signal.

- [ ] The interview is chat-only with no video or phone call and no named hiring manager.
- [ ] The pay is high for very simple work ("$40/hr to like posts").
- [ ] The email comes from a free domain (gmail.com, outlook.com) or a look-alike domain (amaz0n-careers.com).
- [ ] You are asked for your SSN, bank login, or ID photo before a written offer.
- [ ] You are sent a check and asked to buy equipment or forward money.
- [ ] The job does not appear on the company's own careers page.
- [ ] They pressure you to decide today.

Verify in two minutes. (1) Find the listing on the company's official careers page by typing the URL yourself rather than following a link. (2) Check that the recruiter's LinkedIn profile has history and connections at the company. (3) Search "[company] + scam" and "[company] recruiter fraud"; many companies publish fraud notices. (4) Never move off the platform where you found the job before a contract exists.

Risks on legitimate platforms

Real platforms carry real risks too. From the evidence in Chapter 6:

- **No work after acceptance.** Empty queues on Outlier, project droughts on DataAnnotation and Mindrift, long silences at Mercor.
- **Rate cuts between projects.** Business Insider documented cuts at Outlier (from $50 to $15/hr) and on a Mercor follow-on project ($16/hr).
- **Account deactivation without explanation.** Reported on Outlier and DataAnnotation.
- **Payment disputes.** Alignerr contributors report unpaid removals and missing payments. RWS contributors report payment-portal issues.
- **Unpaid assessments.** DataAnnotation, Outlier, TELUS, RWS, and Toptal's test project are typically unpaid. Handshake's training exercise is paid.
- **Worker-paid costs.** Liveops' background check and the historical Arise model.

Protect yourself:

1. **Keep records.** Screenshot the posted rate, save contracts, log hours and task IDs, and keep copies of your submissions where terms allow.
2. **Stop after one unpaid cycle.** If a payment does not arrive on the stated schedule, pause new work and open a support ticket with your records.
3. **Use payment accounts in your legal name** that match your platform profile (PayPal, Stripe, bank). Mismatches trigger holds.
4. **Diversify.** No single platform should be more than about half of your income until it has paid you reliably for three months.

Taxes and benefits basics (US)

- Most AI-training and freelance income is **1099 self-employment income**. You owe income tax plus self-employment tax (Social Security and Medicare, about 15.3% on net earnings). Platforms typically issue a 1099-NEC or 1099-K above federal thresholds. Track all income regardless.

- **Set aside 25–30%** of each payout in a separate savings account. Consider quarterly estimated payments (IRS Form 1040-ES). Deductible business expenses can reduce your tax: a share of home internet, equipment, software subscriptions, and platform fees. Confirm with a tax professional or IRS.gov.
- **Unemployment benefits:** if you are collecting UI, report all part-time and gig earnings exactly as your state requires. Rules differ by state.
- **Health coverage after a layoff:** compare COBRA with marketplace plans at HealthCare.gov. Losing job-based coverage qualifies you for a special enrollment period.

Where to report fraud

- **FTC:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov
- **FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center:** ic3.gov
- **Your state attorney general's** consumer-protection office
- The **impersonated company's** official fraud or security contact
- The **platform** where you met the scammer (LinkedIn, Indeed, Upwork: use "Report")

The one rule: legitimate jobs pay you. You never pay them.

The second rule: stay on the platform until a contract exists.

The third rule: track every hour and every payout from day one.

CHAPTER 6

What Real Workers Report: Success & Failure Patterns

In this chapter: an analysis of 51 documented worker experiences and data points, mostly from 2024–2026: who got accepted, hired, or paid, how long it took, what they did differently, and what went wrong. Each item is labeled by evidence type. The full table with links is in Appendix B and `WORKER_SUCCESS_RESEARCH.csv`.

How to read this evidence

Type	Meaning	How much weight to give it
OFFICIAL	The company states it (process steps, pay rules)	High, for *rules*. Says nothing about how often people succeed.
JOURNALISM	Reported by a news outlet with multiple sources	High.
DATA	Surveys or datasets (FTC, LinkedIn, Huntr, Greenhouse)	High for market patterns.
REVIEWS	Aggregated review-site ratings and themes	Medium. Reviewers skew toward strong opinions.
ANECDOTE	One person's account (forum, blog, Reddit, LinkedIn)	Low on its own. Useful for *patterns* when many agree.

What this evidence can and cannot tell you. It shows that people with certain profiles have been accepted, hired, and paid on these platforms, and what tends to help or hurt. It **cannot** tell you your odds, your timeline, or your income. Several success stories come from people selling courses; they are labeled and weighted down.

Success patterns (what worked)

1. Domain expertise is the strongest predictor of good pay

- Expert listings pay a multiple of generalist rates: Mercor's $50–140/hr expert trainer, Alignerr's $30–150/hr PhD trainer, Handshake's $50–125/hr for graduate students, and Turing's $50–250/hr for developers, versus roughly $12–30/hr for generalist work.
- Bloomberg (November 2025) and the WSJ, via secondary coverage, describe AI startups recruiting bankers, lawyers, engineers, and doctors. Some displaced professionals described the work as a way out of unemployment.
- xAI's September 2025 layoff of generalist tutors, paired with a plan to grow its specialist team 10x, shows where demand is going.

What to do: lead every AI-training application with your *specific* expertise: sub-fields, tools, regulations, document types. “Licensed CPA, 8 years in multistate sales-tax compliance” beats “finance professional.”

2. Preparation for one-shot assessments pays off

- DataAnnotation’s Starter Assessment cannot be retaken, and Mercor lets you redo the AI interview *before* submitting. Candidates who treat these like exams (rested, distraction-free, complete written reasoning) report better outcomes than those who rush.
- Alignerr and micro1 reviewers say the AI interviewer probes the resume closely. Successful candidates describe answering with concrete project detail.

3. Persistence over roughly 2–3 months, with adjustments, wins first freelance clients

- Upwork Community: “about 2 months to land my first client, and 3 weeks after that to land my next.” A freelancer quoted by Upwork waited three months (July to October). Others sent proposals for six months, and several broke through only after **changing their profile and niche**, not by sending more of the same proposals.
- Fiverr sellers report first orders after about three weeks, and **repeat orders** from a delighted first buyer.

4. Networks and recruiters beat cold applications for salaried remote jobs

- A remote-only seeker sent 53 applications for 1 offer. Another poster in the same thread found LinkedIn recruiter leads converted far better and got their offer through their personal network.
- A laid-off marketing account manager needed 1,000+ applications, and said she would cast a *narrower* net from the start.
- A laid-off developer logged 152 applications, 6 interviews, and 101 ghostings in three months.
- Remote postings drew **42% of LinkedIn applications while making up 8.4% of postings**. Cold-applying to remote roles is the most crowded channel there is.

5. Stacking small, reliable sources covers the gap

- Prolific earners on r/beermoney logged roughly $150–$500 a month in 2025. Small amounts, but paid on a minimum-rate floor ($8/hr).
- Indeed and Glassdoor reviewers rate DataAnnotation 4.1/5 and say pay is prompt. Mercor reviewers praise weekly pay.

Failure patterns (what went wrong)

Pattern	Where it’s reported	How to avoid it
Silent rejection / ghosting after assessment or AI interview	DataAnnotation, Mercor, TELUS	Apply to 3+ platforms in parallel; set a 3-week “move on” rule
Empty queue after acceptance	Outlier, DataAnnotation, Mindrift, Appen	Treat acceptance as an option, not a job; keep applying
Rate cuts between projects	Outlier ($50→$15/hr), Mercor follow-on ($16/hr)	Re-check rate at every project start; specialize
Account deactivation without explanation	Outlier, DataAnnotation	Follow guidelines exactly; never use AI on tasks; diversify

Pattern	Where it's reported	How to avoid it
Unpaid work disputes	Alignerr, RWS	Log hours/task IDs; stop after one unpaid cycle
Using AI on tasks	Mercor/AI-training projects (removals reported)	Write everything yourself
Generic freelance profile	Upwork/Fiverr newcomers	Niche title, matching portfolio samples
Mass cold-applying for remote jobs	2025 job-search accounts	Fewer, tailored applications plus outreach to the hiring team
Paying to work	Liveops (background check), Arise (training/equipment)	Prefer W-2 roles; compute real hourly first
Falling for task scams	FTC data	Never pay to get paid

Timelines reported

Milestone	Reported range	Source type
DataAnnotation decision after assessment	Days to ~4 weeks (silent if rejected)	Reviews / official FAQ
DataAnnotation first payout after work	~3–7 days after submission	Community FAQ
Outlier onboarding	30–90 min general + project qualifiers	Official
Mercor response after interview	2 weeks to 6 months, or never	Reviews
First Upwork client	6 days to 6 months; ~2–3 months common	Anecdotes (forum)
First Fiverr order	~1–3 weeks for some; never for others	Anecdotes (forum)
Salaried job offer	Median 68.5 days (Huntr Q2 2025)	Data

What the evidence says about *who* succeeds

The documented successes share traits more than backgrounds: they **(1)** matched a platform to a real, specific skill; **(2)** prepared for the gate (assessment, AI interview, proposal) as a skill in itself; **(3)** ran several channels at once; and **(4)** adjusted after silence instead of repeating the same approach. The documented failures most often relied on one platform, used generic positioning, or treated acceptance as a guaranteed income.

Bottom line: these platforms do pay real people. The evidence for that is strong for Mercor, DataAnnotation, Outlier, and Prolific. *Steady* work is the exception.

Plan accordingly: stack sources for income, and run a targeted, network-driven search for stability.

CHAPTER 7

How to Get Accepted: Platform-by-Platform

In this chapter: the verified stages for each major platform, from registration to paid work, followed by original mock assessments with strong example answers, the question categories you will face, common mistakes, and preparation checklists. Stages vary by platform, so check the table before you start.

The stages, verified per platform

Platform	Registration	Profile/CV	Assessment	Interview	Onboarding	Paid work starts when…
Mercor	Account	Resume upload drives the interview	Role-specific (some listings)	~20-min AI video interview (practice + redo before submit); sometimes human call	Contract, Stripe setup	You're selected for a project; hourly, paid weekly
DataAnnotation	Apply on site	Basic info	Starter Assessment (~1 hr, one attempt, unpaid)	None	Paid qualifications	Projects appear on dashboard
Outlier	Account	Choose expertise	Skill screening (unpaid)	None (generally)	ID verification + project qualifiers (unpaid)	Tasks are available in your queue
Alignerr	Apply to listing	Resume	Domain assessment (often one attempt)	AI interview ("Zara") on many roles	ID verification, contract	Invited to a project
micro1	Opportunities portal	Resume	Skill-based interview	AI interview ("Zara"), 30–60 min reported	ID verification → "certified expert"	Matched to a contract
Handshake AI	Fellowship sign-up	Resume, profile verification	Some projects add assessments	None standard	Government ID; **paid** training exercise	Matched to project
TELUS Digital	Apply to US listing	Profile verification	Qualification exam on guidelines (unpaid)	None standard	Program training	Hours become available
Prolific	Register (may be waitlisted)	"About You" screeners	Attention checks inside studies	None	ID checks	Studies appear
Toptal	Application	Resume	Timed skill test + test project (1–3 wks)	Language/personality + live technical	Profile build	Client match

Platform	Registration	Profile/CV	Assessment	Interview	Onboarding	Paid work starts when...
Upwork	Sign up	Profile approval	None (optional skill tests)	Client chats/calls	ID verification (often after 1st contract)	Contract accepted, milestone funded
W-2 customer service	Employer careers site	Resume	Typing, situational judgment, speed test	Virtual interview	Background check, paid training	First scheduled shift

The universal acceptance checklist

Before any assessment or AI interview

- ☐ Read every instruction twice. Most failures are instruction-following failures, not knowledge failures.
- ☐ Block 60–90 uninterrupted minutes. Turn off notifications and close other tabs.
- ☐ Use a laptop or desktop (not a phone), a stable connection, a working webcam and mic, and good front lighting.
- ☐ Have your resume open. AI interviewers ask about it.
- ☐ Prepare 3 project stories (2 minutes each) with numbers.
- ☐ Do not use ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Grammarly, or translation tools *during* the assessment. Platforms detect it and will remove you.
- ☐ Write in complete sentences. Show your reasoning, not just your answer.
- ☐ Proofread once before submitting.

Question categories you will face

Category	Example	What graders look for
Instruction following	"Answer in exactly 3 bullet points under 50 words."	Every constraint met
Response comparison	"Which response is better? Explain."	Correct choice, specific reasons tied to a rubric
Fact-checking	"Identify all errors in this paragraph."	Finding subtle errors; not inventing false ones
Writing an ideal response	"Write the response an expert assistant should give."	Accuracy, completeness, tone, format
Safety judgment	"Should the assistant comply with this request?"	Recognizing harm; helpful refusal or safe alternative
Domain depth (expert roles)	"Explain why this tax treatment is wrong."	Real expertise, precise terms
Coding	"Find the bug; write tests."	Correct diagnosis, clean fix, edge cases
Rater guidelines	"Rate this search result's relevance (Fully Meets → Fails to Meet)."	Consistency with the guideline definitions

Category	Example	What graders look for
Resume deep-dive (AI interview)	"Walk me through your role on [project]."	Specifics, ownership, results
Behavioral (employers)	"Tell me about a time you handled an angry customer."	STAR structure, empathy, outcome

Mock Assessment 1: Compare two AI responses

These mock items are original practice material. They do not reproduce any platform's real test.

User prompt: "Explain compound interest to a 12-year-old in under 100 words, with one example."

> **Response A (148 words):** "Compound interest is when the interest you earn gets added to your principal, and then future interest is calculated on the new, larger principal. This is different from simple interest, which is only calculated on the original amount. Financial institutions use an annual percentage yield (APY) to show this. For example, if you deposit $100 at 10% interest compounded annually, after one year you have $110. In year two, you earn 10% of $110, which is $11, so you have $121. Over long time horizons, compounding can significantly increase the value of savings, which is why starting early matters..."

> **Response B (82 words):** "Imagine your money is a snowball rolling downhill. The bank pays you a little extra money, called interest, for keeping your money there. Next time, it pays interest on your money *plus* the interest you already earned, so the snowball grows faster. Example: put $100 in a bank that pays 10% each year. After one year you have $110. After two years you have $120. The longer you wait, the bigger it gets!"

Task: Which response is better? Explain in 3–5 sentences.

Strong answer: *Response A is better, though both have problems.* Response B has a factual error in its only example: at 10% compounded annually, $110 grows to **$121**, not $120. $120 is simple interest, which is exactly the concept it was meant to contrast, so the error defeats the purpose of the explanation. Response A's math is correct, but it breaks two instructions: it is about 148 words (limit: 100), and it uses terms like "principal" and "APY" that a 12-year-old would not know. Because accuracy outranks style and length in most rating rubrics, A is preferable. An ideal answer would combine B's tone and length with A's correct example.

Why it's strong: it picks a side, names the decisive factor (factual accuracy), points to the exact error, credits and faults each response specifically, and says what "ideal" would look like.

Common mistakes: choosing B because "it's more kid-friendly" without checking the math; saying "both are fine"; vague reasons ("A is more detailed").

Mock Assessment 2: Write an ideal response under constraints

Prompt: “I just got laid off. Give me a checklist for my first 48 hours. Max 8 bullets, plain language, US-specific.”

Strong answer:

- File for unemployment in the state where you worked, today if possible. Benefits usually start from your filing date.
- Get your final paycheck details, severance terms, and any agreement *in writing*. Don’t sign a release until you understand it.
- Ask HR how and when your health coverage ends. Compare COBRA with a HealthCare.gov plan (a layoff opens a special enrollment period).
- Download your pay stubs, W-2s, performance reviews, and contacts you’re allowed to keep before your access ends.
- Ask about unused PTO payout and 401(k) options. Don’t cash out retirement funds without checking the tax penalties.
- Update your LinkedIn and resume with your most recent results while they’re fresh.
- Tell 10 people you trust that you’re looking, and name the role you want.
- Make a 30-day budget and list which bills can be paused or reduced.

Why it’s strong: it meets every constraint (8 bullets, plain words, US-specific), puts the time-sensitive steps first, is accurate (filing date matters; a layoff triggers special enrollment), and adds practical caution without giving legal advice.

Mock Assessment 3: Fact-check this paragraph

Paragraph: “Independent contractors receive a Form W-2 from each client at the end of the year. They pay self-employment tax of 15.3%, which covers Social Security and Medicare, and the Social Security portion applies to all net earnings with no upper limit. Quarterly estimated tax payments are generally due in April, June, September, and January. The Fair Labor Standards Act guarantees overtime pay to independent contractors who work more than 40 hours a week.”

Task: Identify and correct every error.

Strong answer: There are three errors. (1) Contractors receive **Form 1099-NEC** (or 1099-K from payment platforms), not a W-2, which is for employees. (2) The Social Security portion (12.4%) applies only up to an **annual wage base limit**, which is adjusted every year; the Medicare portion (2.9%) has no cap. (3) The FLSA’s overtime protections cover **employees**, not independent contractors. **Correct as written:** the 15.3% combined self-employment tax rate, and the four estimated-payment months (generally April 15, June 15, September 15, and January 15 of the following year).

Why it's strong: it finds all the errors, confirms what is correct (graders penalize "finding" errors that aren't there), and gives the precise correction.

Mock Assessment 4: Coding evaluation

Task: The function should return the average of a list of numbers, or `None` for an empty list. Find the bug(s), fix them, and give two test cases.

```
def average(nums):
    total = 0
    for i in range(1, len(nums)):
        total += nums[i]
    return total / len(nums)
```

Strong answer: Two bugs. (1) `range(1, len(nums))` skips the first element, so `average([2, 4])` returns 2.0 instead of 3.0. (2) An empty list raises `ZeroDivisionError` instead of returning `None`.

```
def average(nums):
    if not nums:
        return None
    return sum(nums) / len(nums)

assert average([2, 4]) == 3.0
assert average([]) is None
```

Why it's strong: it states each bug with a concrete failing input, gives a minimal idiomatic fix, and adds tests for the normal case and the edge case.

Mock Assessment 5: Search relevance rating

Query: "remote customer service jobs texas"

Rate each result **Highly relevant / Somewhat relevant / Not relevant** and justify in one sentence.

1. A careers page listing "Work-from-home Customer Service Advisor — must reside in TX, FL or GA."
2. A blog post titled "10 Tips for Great Customer Service."
3. A job listing for "On-site Customer Service Rep — Dallas, TX office."

Strong answer: (1) **Highly relevant.** It is a remote customer-service job open to Texas residents, matching all three parts of the query. (2) **Not relevant.** It is about customer service skills, not jobs, and has no remote or location component. (3) **Somewhat relevant.** It matches "customer service" and "Texas" but fails the "remote" intent, which is central to the query.

Why it's strong: it breaks the query into its parts (job type, remote, location) and rates consistently against them, which is what rater guidelines reward.

Mock Assessment 6: AI interview (expert/resume-based)

AI interviewers on Mercor, Alignerr, and micro1 typically ask you to go deep on your own experience, explain a concept in your field, and judge or improve an answer. Practice these aloud with a 2-minute timer:

1. "Walk me through the most complex project on your resume. What was your specific role?"
2. "Explain [a core concept in your field] to a smart non-expert."
3. "Here is an answer an AI gave about [topic]. What is wrong with it, and how would you fix it?"
4. "How do you check that your own work is correct before you submit it?"
5. "Tell me about a time you found an error others missed."

Example strong answer to Q1 (laid-off healthcare billing specialist): "At [Clinic Group] I led the cleanup of a claims backlog after an EHR migration. About 2,300 claims were stuck because diagnosis codes didn't map correctly to the new system. My role was to define the mapping rules for the top 40 denial reasons, train three coworkers, and audit a sample every week. I built a spreadsheet that flagged mismatched ICD-10 codes before submission. Over four months, our first-pass acceptance rate went from about 78% to 93%, and the backlog cleared. The lesson I'd bring to evaluating AI answers is that small coding errors look plausible, so I verify each one against the source rule rather than trusting how it reads."

Why it's strong: clear ownership ("my role was…"), precise domain terms, real numbers, a method, and a bridge to the AI-evaluation job. *Use your own true details. The numbers here are illustrative.*

Mock Assessment 7: Customer service chat simulation

Customer: "This is the THIRD time my order is late. I want a refund NOW or I'm disputing the charge."

Strong reply: "I'm sorry. Three late deliveries is frustrating, and I'd be upset too. I've pulled up your order # [ID]. It's currently at [status]. I can do one of two things right now: issue a full refund to your original payment method today (it usually posts in 3–5 business days), or ship a replacement with free expedited delivery arriving [date]. Which would you prefer?"

Why it's strong: it acknowledges the emotion without arguing, shows you took action, offers concrete choices within policy, and ends with a clear question. Assessments score empathy, ownership, accuracy, and resolution.

Most common reasons people fail

1. **Missing an instruction** (word limit, format, "explain why").
2. **Vague justifications** ("A is better because it's clearer").
3. **Inventing errors** in fact-checks, or missing the decisive one.
4. **Using AI tools** on the assessment.
5. **Rushing.** Speed is rarely scored at the entry gate; quality is.
6. **A generic resume** that gives the AI interviewer nothing specific to ask about.
7. **Poor setup**: noise, bad lighting, an unstable connection during video interviews.
8. **Applying to roles outside your verifiable expertise.**

Preparation plan (2–3 hours, once)

- [ ] Run prompt **P16** (Assessment Practice Generator) and complete two full practice sets.
- [ ] Run prompt **P14** in "AI-training platform screening" mode with your resume; repeat until you average 4/5.
- [ ] Write out your 3 resume stories using STAR (prompt **P15**).
- [ ] Read any public guidelines for your target rater program (search "[platform] rater guidelines").
- [ ] Test webcam, mic, and lighting; do Mercor's practice interview if you're applying there.
- [ ] Prepare a quiet 90-minute block for the real assessment.

Most assessments test one skill: careful instruction-following plus visible reasoning.

AI interviews test another: specific, confident explanations of your own real work.

Practice both with prompts P14–P16 before you take a one-shot test.

CHAPTER 8

Freelancing: From Profile to First Paid Client

> **In this chapter:** a step-by-step system for building a portfolio from scratch, writing a profile that converts, finding and winning the first client, pricing so you still earn after fees and taxes, and communicating like a professional. It works on Upwork, Fiverr, and Contra, and with clients you find yourself.

Step 1: Choose a narrow, sellable offer (30 minutes)

Clients hire people who solve *their* problem, not generalists. Write one sentence:

> **I help [specific client] [achieve specific outcome] by [service], delivered in [timeframe].**

Too broad	Sellable
"Virtual assistant"	"I help real-estate agents keep their inbox, calendar and CRM up to date, 10 hrs/week."
"Writer"	"I write SEO blog posts for B2B SaaS startups, 2 per week, researched and optimized."
"Data analyst"	"I turn messy Shopify exports into a weekly Google Sheets sales dashboard in 3 days."
"AI consultant"	"I set up ChatGPT/Claude workflows and templates for 5–20 person service businesses in one week."

Test it: search the job board for your offer. If you find 20+ posts from the last week, there is demand.

Step 2: Build a portfolio with no clients (2–6 hours)

You do not need paid clients to show proof. You need **samples that look like the client's problem**, labeled honestly.

1. **Self-initiated samples.** Pick a real public business in your niche and create what you would deliver: a redesigned landing page, a sample newsletter, a cleaned dataset, an SOP. Label it "Sample project, not commissioned."
2. **Past work you may show.** Redact confidential details, or describe the work without sharing files.
3. **Volunteer and small-business work.** Do one project for a nonprofit or a friend's business in exchange for a testimonial and permission to show it.
4. **Case-study format.** Use prompt **P10** to turn each sample into a one-page case study: problem → approach → result.

Host the portfolio on **Contra** (free), Upwork's portfolio section, Behance/Dribbble (design), GitHub (code), or a Google Drive folder with view-only links.

Step 3: Write a profile that converts

Before (Upwork title): “Hardworking Virtual Assistant | Data Entry | Admin | Anything You Need”

After: “Executive Assistant for Real-Estate Agents | Inbox, Calendar & Follow Up Boss CRM”

Before (overview opening): “Hello! My name is Jordan and I am a hardworking, detail-oriented professional with a passion for helping businesses succeed…”

After: “Losing leads because follow-ups slip through the cracks? I spent 4 years as an office coordinator for a 12-agent brokerage, where I managed the team’s calendar, inbox triage and CRM updates (up to 150 contacts a week). I can do the same for you: inbox at zero daily, every showing confirmed, every lead logged in Follow Up Boss within 24 hours.”

Profile checklist: niche title · first 2 lines state the client’s problem and your proof · 2–3 portfolio items · clear list of what’s included · professional photo · rate set (Step 5) · skills tags that match job-post keywords. Use prompt **P09**.

Step 4: Win the first client

Where first clients actually come from

1. **Your existing network (fastest).** Message 20 former colleagues, managers, and clients: “I’ve started offering [service]. Do you know anyone who needs help with [problem]?” Many freelancers’ first paid project comes from someone who already trusts them.
2. **Fresh job posts.** On Upwork, filter for posts from the **last 24 hours**, *payment verified*, and budgets that match your offer. Early proposals get read. Older posts are buried.
3. **Small, low-risk first jobs.** A $50–150 fixed-price task with a fast turnaround builds the first review. Some freelancers deliberately accept a lower first rate to earn reviews. Decide your floor in advance.
4. **Fiverr inquiries.** Reply within an hour. Response time affects visibility and conversion.
5. **Direct outreach.** Find 10 small businesses in your niche with a visible, fixable problem (a broken booking link, no email newsletter). Send a short note with one specific fix (template in Chapter 11).

The proposal formula (Upwork)

The client sees the first one or two lines in a preview. Make them about **their** goal.

Weak proposal: “Dear Sir/Madam, I am an experienced freelancer with excellent communication skills. I have read your job post and I am confident I am the best fit. Please check my profile. Thank you.”

Strong proposal (128 words): “You need last quarter’s Shopify orders turned into a dashboard your team can check every Monday, without touching formulas.

Here’s how I’d do it: 1. Clean the export (fix duplicate SKUs and refund rows) in Google Sheets. 2. Build a summary tab: revenue by week, top 10 products, repeat-customer rate. 3. Add a one-click refresh and a 5-minute Loom walkthrough for your team.

Sample of a similar dashboard (self-initiated, using public demo data): [link]

One question: do you want refunds netted out of revenue, or shown separately?

I can deliver a first version in 3 business days.”

Proposal rules: under 150 words · first line restates their goal · 2–4 concrete steps · one relevant proof link · one smart question · a timeline. Use prompt **P12**, then rewrite it in your own voice.

Step 5: Price so you actually earn

Formula: `Quote = (target take-home hourly × hours) ÷ (1 - platform fee)`, then set aside about 25–30% of what you receive for taxes.

Example: You want $35/hr take-home before tax, the job is 6 hours, and the Upwork fee shown is 10%. Quote = (35 × 6) ÷ 0.90 = **$233** (round to $235). On Fiverr (20% fee): (35 × 6) ÷ 0.80 = **$263**.

Pricing model	Use when	Watch out
Fixed price with milestones	Clear deliverable	Define scope and revisions in writing
Hourly	Ongoing or unclear scope	Use Upwork’s tracker for payment protection
Packages (good/better/best)	Fiverr, Contra, repeat services	Make the middle package the one you want to sell
Retainer	Repeat clients (e.g., 10 hrs/week VA)	Agree on rollover rules and response times

Step 6: Communicate like a professional

After the client accepts:

> “Thanks, [Name]! To confirm the scope: [deliverables], [deadline], [number] rounds of revisions. I’ll send a first draft by [date/time ET]. Anything I should know about your brand or preferences before I start?”

Midpoint update:

> “Quick update: [what’s done]. On track for [date]. One decision for you: [question].”

Delivery:

> "Here's the final [deliverable]: [link]. Summary of what's included: [bullets]. If anything needs adjusting, I'm happy to make [remaining] revision(s). If you're happy with the work, a short review helps me a lot."

Scope creep:

> "Happy to add [new request]. It's outside our original scope, so I can do it as a small add-on for $[X], delivered by [date]. Want me to go ahead?"

Late payment (off-platform clients):

> "Hi [Name], a friendly reminder that invoice #[ID] for $[X] was due on [date]. Here's the payment link: [link]. Let me know if anything's needed on your side."

Step 7: Turn one client into a business

- **Ask for the review** right after a successful delivery.
- **Offer the next step:** "Would a monthly version of this be useful?"
- **Request referrals:** "Do you know one other [type of business] who'd benefit from this?"
- **Raise rates** after 3–5 five-star reviews, for new clients first.
- **Keep everything on-platform** with platform clients. Fee avoidance violates most marketplace terms and removes your payment protection.

Narrow offer → honest samples → specific proposals → fair pricing → professional updates → reviews.

Plan for about 2–3 months to land the first clients (forum reports range from 6 days to 6 months), and improve your profile each week instead of only sending more proposals.

CHAPTER 9

AI-Powered Resume & Application Workflow

> **In this chapter:** a repeatable 45-minute workflow that takes one real job posting to a tailored, truthful, ATS-readable resume, a LinkedIn or freelance profile, a cover note, and an application-ready PDF. All of it uses free tools: ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Google Docs, or Microsoft Word. The full prompt library is in `AI_CAREER_PROMPTS.md`, and the key prompts are reproduced here.

The non-negotiable rule: never invent

AI assistants will happily make up a certification, a metric, or a job title that "sounds right." Every prompt in this book tells the AI not to, and uses placeholders such as **[ADD METRIC?]** instead of guesses. You must still check every line. Invented qualifications can surface in background checks, reference calls, interviews, or a platform's domain assessment, and on AI-training platforms the expertise you claim is the expertise you will be tested on.

What ATS systems actually do (2026)

- Most applicant tracking systems **parse** your resume into fields and let recruiters **search and filter** by keywords. Reports that "75% of resumes are auto-rejected by ATS" are widely described as overblown. Many systems do not auto-reject on content. Knockout questions (work authorization, location, required license) are the more common automatic filters.
- **Parsing problems are real.** Contact details placed in headers or footers, tables, text boxes, multiple columns, and images can be misread. A simple single-column document parses best.
- **Text-based PDFs are fine** for most modern systems. Submit a .docx when the employer asks for it.
- **Keywords still matter** because recruiters search for them. Mirror the posting's exact phrasing *where it truthfully describes you* ("customer success" vs. "client support," "SQL" vs. "databases").

The 45-minute workflow

1. **Decode the job (5 min).** Paste the full posting into prompt P01. Save the must-haves and keywords.
2. **Check fit honestly (5 min).** P02 compares your resume to the job. Skip jobs below about 6/10 unless you have a referral.
3. **Tailor the resume (15 min).** P03 rewrites it with the job's keywords, using only your facts. Answer P04's questions to add real metrics.
4. **Write the note (5 min).** P11 produces a cover letter under 200 words (or P12 for an Upwork proposal).
5. **QA and export (10 min).** P21 checks consistency. Paste into the template below, export to PDF, and check how it reads.
6. **Log it (5 min).** Add the application to your Workbook tracker with a follow-up date 5–7 days out.

The prompts you'll use most

P01 — Job Description Decoder

Use this first, on every job you care about.

```
You are a senior US recruiter. Analyze the job description below.

Return:
1. The 5 must-have qualifications (quote the exact wording).
2. The 5 nice-to-have qualifications.
3. The 12 most important keywords/phrases an ATS or recruiter would search for, exactly as written in the
posting.
4. The real problem this hire is meant to solve, in one sentence.
5. Red flags or unclear points (pay, location limits, contractor vs W-2, unpaid tests, upfront fees).
6. Three questions I should be ready to answer in a screening call.

Job description:
"""
[PASTE FULL JOB DESCRIPTION]
"""
```

P02 — Honest Fit Check

```
Compare my resume to this job description. Be blunt and specific.

Rules: Use only facts in my resume. Do not assume skills I have not listed.

Return a table: Requirement | Evidence from my resume (quote it) | Match (Strong / Partial / Missing) | How
to close the gap honestly (reword, add a real project, or skip this job).
Then give an overall fit score from 1 to 10 and say whether I should apply, apply with a referral, or skip.

Job description:
"""
[PASTE]
"""
My resume:
"""
[PASTE]
"""
```

P03 — ATS-Ready Resume Tailor

```
Act as a US resume writer who builds ATS-readable resumes.

Rewrite my resume for the job below. Rules:
- Use ONLY information in my resume and the extra notes I provide. Never invent employers, dates, titles,
degrees, certifications, tools, or numbers. If a metric would help but I did not give one, insert [ADD
METRIC?] instead of guessing.
- Single column, no tables, no text boxes, no icons, no headers/footers for contact info.
- Standard section headings: Summary, Skills, Experience, Education, Certifications (only if I have them),
Projects (only if I have them).
- Mirror the job's exact keywords where they truthfully describe my work.
- Each bullet: strong verb + what I did + tool/method + result. Max 2 lines.
- Most relevant role gets 4–6 bullets; older roles 2–3.
- Keep it to 1 page if under 10 years of experience, otherwise max 2 pages.
- After the resume, list every change you made and every [ADD METRIC?] placeholder so I can verify.

Job description:
```

```
"""
[PASTE]
"""
My current resume:
"""
[PASTE]
"""
Extra true facts I can add (optional):
"""
[e.g., "Trained 4 new hires", "Handled ~60 tickets/day in Zendesk"]
"""
```

P04 — Bullet Point Upgrader (with metric interview)

```
Here are weak resume bullets. For each one, ask me up to 3 short questions to uncover real scope and results (volume, time saved, money, quality, people, tools). Wait for my answers. Then rewrite each bullet using only my answers. Do not guess numbers.

Bullets:
[PASTE 3-8 BULLETS]
```

Before and after: a real-world style rewrite

Target posting (summary): *Remote Customer Success Associate, B2B SaaS. Must-haves: 2+ yrs customer-facing experience, Zendesk or similar, ability to manage 50+ accounts, strong written communication. Nice: SQL basics, onboarding experience.*

Before

> **Retail Store Supervisor**, Target, 2021–2025
>
> - Responsible for helping customers
> - Managed team members
> - Handled returns and complaints
> - Did inventory

After (using only facts the candidate confirmed via P04)

> **Retail Store Supervisor**, Target · Austin, TX · Jun 2021 – Mar 2025
>
> - Resolved 40–60 customer issues per shift (returns, order problems, escalations) while maintaining store guest-satisfaction scores above district average.
> - Trained and scheduled a team of 9; onboarded 14 new hires using a checklist I created, cutting ramp-up time from about 3 weeks to 2.
> - Managed the store's online-order pickup queue (~120 orders/day) in the company's order-management system; flagged recurring errors to regional support.
> - Wrote weekly shift summaries for the store manager covering incidents, customer feedback themes, and staffing gaps.

What changed: ownership verbs, real volumes, the posting's language ("customer issues," "escalations," "onboarded"), and a written-communication proof point. **What did not change:** the title, the employer, and the facts. Zendesk was *not* added because the candidate has not used it; it goes in the cover note as "quick to learn new ticketing tools, e.g., our order-management system."

ATS-friendly resume template (copy into Google Docs or Word)

```
FIRST LAST
City, ST · email@domain.com · linkedin.com/in/yourname · (portfolio link, optional)

SUMMARY
[Target title] with [X years] in [domain]. [Top proof point with number]. [Second proof point]. Seeking
[remote role type].

SKILLS
[8–14 skills/tools, mirroring the posting's exact wording where true]

EXPERIENCE
```

```
Job Title, Employer · City, ST (or Remote) · Mon YYYY – Mon YYYY
- Verb + what you did + tool/method + measurable result.
- (4–6 bullets for the most relevant role; 2–3 for older roles)

PROJECTS (optional; great for new grads and career switchers)
Project Name · Tools · Mon YYYY
- What it does, who it's for, the result or link.

EDUCATION
Degree, Major · School · Year  (GPA if 3.3+ and within 3 years of graduating)

CERTIFICATIONS (only real, current ones)
```

Formatting rules: a standard font (Calibri, Arial, Garamond) at 10.5–12 pt · 0.5–1″ margins · no tables, columns, icons, or photos · contact info in the body, not the header · consistent dates · one page (two if you have more than 10 years of relevant experience).

Profiles, portfolios, and cover letters

P07 — Laid-Off Professional Repositioning

```
I was laid off from [COMPANY/INDUSTRY] after [X] years as [TITLE]. I am targeting (a) remote roles like
[ROLE A], and (b) short-term income through expert AI-training work (Mercor, Alignerr, Handshake, micro1)
and/or freelance consulting.

From my resume below, produce:
1. A one-line LinkedIn headline for each target (a) and (b).
2. A 4-sentence "expert profile" paragraph for AI-training platforms that names my specific domain knowledge
(sub-fields, tools, regulations, document types I can judge).
3. A list of 10 specific topics I could credibly evaluate AI answers on.
4. A one-sentence, non-defensive way to explain the layoff.

Use only real facts. No invented achievements.

Resume:
"""
[PASTE]
"""
```

P08 — LinkedIn Profile Rebuild

```
Rewrite my LinkedIn profile for recruiters searching for [TARGET ROLE] in remote US roles.

Deliver:
1. Headline (max 220 characters): role + specialty + proof + target. Give 3 options.
2. About section (180–260 words): first 2 lines must hook a recruiter; include 8–10 searchable keywords
naturally; end with what I'm looking for and how to contact me (no phone number).
3. Experience: rewrite my 2 most recent roles in 3–5 bullets each.
4. Top 10 skills to list, ordered by recruiter search value.
5. A "Featured" section plan: 3 items I could add.

Only use facts from my resume. Flag anything you'd like me to confirm.

Resume:
"""
[PASTE]
"""
```

P09 — Upwork / Fiverr / Contra Profile Builder

```
Create a freelance profile for [PLATFORM] selling [SERVICE] to [TARGET CLIENT TYPE].

Return:
1. Title (max 70 characters) that names the outcome and the niche. 3 options.
2. Overview (Upwork: 200–300 words) that starts with the client's problem, shows 2–3 proof points from my
real experience, lists what's included, and ends with a clear call to action.
3. For Fiverr: gig title, 3 packages (Basic/Standard/Premium) with scope, delivery time, revisions, and
starting prices based on my target hourly rate of $[RATE].
4. 5 FAQ entries.
5. 3 portfolio-piece ideas I can create this week from real or self-initiated work, clearly labeled as
samples.

Rules: No fake reviews, clients, or credentials. If I have no clients yet, do not imply that I do.

My background and skills:
"""
[PASTE]
"""
```

P11 — Cover Letter / Application Note (short)

```
Write a cover letter for the job below in under 200 words.

Structure:
1. One sentence that names the role and a specific thing about the company (from the job post or their
website text I paste).
2. Two short proof paragraphs, each tying one must-have requirement to a real result from my resume.
3. One sentence on why remote work suits how I work (async communication, time zone, tools).
4. Simple close.

No clichés ("I am writing to express my interest", "passionate", "team player"). No invented facts.

Job description:
"""
[PASTE]
"""
Company info (optional):
"""
[PASTE]
"""
My resume:
"""
[PASTE]
"""
```

Also in the library: **P05** (career-switcher translator), **P06** (new-grad resume builder), **P10** (portfolio case study), **P12** (Upwork proposal), and **P13** (pricing calculator).

Exporting application-ready PDFs

1. **Google Docs:** File → Download → PDF Document (.pdf). **Word:** File → Save As → PDF (choose “Best for electronic distribution and accessibility”).
2. **Name the file** `First-Last-Resume-[Role].pdf` (e.g., `Jordan-Lee-Resume-Customer-Success.pdf`).

3. **Test it:** open the PDF, press Ctrl/Cmd+A, copy, and paste into a plain-text editor. If the text comes out in order with your contact line at the top, it parses well. If it's scrambled, remove columns and tables.
4. **Keep a master resume** (everything you've done) and save each tailored version in a folder per application.
5. **Design tools** (Canva and similar) produce attractive resumes, but templates with columns and graphics can parse poorly. Use them for a portfolio, not for the resume you submit to an ATS.

Free and freemium tools

Need	Free options	Notes
Drafting and tailoring	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Microsoft Copilot (free tiers)	Free tiers have usage limits. Keep personal data out.
Resume document	Google Docs, Microsoft Word (free web version)	Export to PDF as above
Keyword comparison	P01/P02 prompts; freemium resume-scan tools	Free tiers are typically limited to a few scans
Portfolio	Contra, Behance, GitHub, Google Drive	Free
Interview practice	Google Interview Warmup (free, US), Yoodli (free tier/university access)	See Chapter 10
Job tracking	Google Sheets / the Action Workbook tracker	Free

Every application: P01 → P02 → P03 (+P04) → P11 → P21 → PDF test → log it.

Truth check: if you cannot explain a resume line in an interview, delete it.

Time budget: 45 minutes per targeted application beats 5 minutes per mass application.

CHAPTER 10

AI Interview Preparation

In this chapter: free practice tools, a reusable AI Interview Simulator prompt that covers beginner and professional levels, practice questions with model answers for five interview types, a scoring rubric, and an improvement loop. You will meet AI interviewers (Mercor, Alignerr's and micro1's "Zara," Braintrust's AIR) as well as human ones, so practice for both.

Practice tools

Tool	Cost	Best for	Notes
Google Interview Warmup	Free (US)	Common questions; voice or typed answers; pattern feedback	Not graded; answers not saved
Mercor practice interview	Free (with account)	Rehearsing Mercor's AI video format	Official Mercor guidance
Yoodli	Free tier; free via some universities	Mock interviews generated from a job description; delivery feedback	Check current plan limits
Big Interview	Usually via a university or workforce login	Structured courses and recorded mock interviews	Ask your career office or American Job Center
ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini with prompt P14	Free tiers	Fully customized mock interviews, scoring, follow-ups	Use voice mode where available to practice speaking
Your phone's camera	Free	Watching yourself on video	Check eye line, lighting, filler words

The AI Interview Simulator

Paste this once, choose a mode, and practice. Repeat with different modes until your average score reaches 4/5.

P14 — AI Interview Simulator (master prompt)

```
You are my interview coach and interviewer. Run a realistic mock interview, one question at a time.

SETTINGS
- Interview type: [Behavioral | Customer service | AI-training platform screening (e.g.,
Mercor/Alignerr/micro1 AI interview) | Freelance client discovery call | Startup founder interview |
Technical/role-specific: ___]
- Target role: [ROLE] at [COMPANY or "a remote US company"]
- My level: [Beginner / Experienced professional]
- Number of questions: [6]
- My resume (for resume-based questions):
"""
[PASTE]
"""
- Job description (optional):
"""
```

```
[PASTE]
"""

RULES
1. Ask ONE question, then stop and wait for my answer.
2. After each answer, score it 1-5 on each: Relevance, Specificity (numbers, examples), Structure (STAR or clear logic), Conciseness (60-120 seconds spoken), Credibility (no vague claims).
3. Give: one thing that worked, the single most important fix, and a rewritten model answer using ONLY facts I gave (mark any assumed detail as [YOUR DETAIL]).
4. Ask one realistic follow-up question an interviewer would ask, then move on.
5. For "AI-training platform screening" mode: ask about my domain expertise in depth (explain a concept, judge a flawed answer, describe a past project step by step), as an AI interviewer would.
6. For "Freelance client" mode: play a client with a vague brief and a tight budget; reward me for clarifying questions and scoping.
7. At the end: overall score, my 3 recurring weaknesses, and a 15-minute drill plan to fix them.

Start with a one-line intro, then question 1.
```

P15 — STAR Story Bank Builder

```
Help me build 8 STAR stories (Situation, Task, Action, Result) from my experience for behavioral interviews.

Cover: a conflict, a mistake, a tight deadline, a difficult customer, leading without authority, learning something fast, improving a process, handling ambiguity.

Ask me 2 questions per story to get real details. Then write each story in 120-150 words (spoken ~60-90 seconds). Use my facts only. Finish with a table mapping each story to 3 common questions it can answer.
```

Scoring rubric (use it yourself or let the AI score you)

Dimension	1 (weak)	3 (adequate)	5 (strong)
Relevance	Off-topic	Answers the question generally	Answers exactly what was asked and ties it to the role
Specificity	No examples	One example, few details	Concrete example with numbers, tools, names of methods
Structure	Rambling	Some order	Clear STAR, or “point → reason → example → result”
Conciseness	> 3 min or < 20 sec	2–3 min	60–120 seconds
Credibility	Vague claims, buzzwords	Plausible	Specific ownership (“I did…”), honest about limits
Delivery (video)	Reading, poor audio	Some eye contact	Steady pace, camera-level eyes, few fillers

Practice questions with model answers

Model answers show structure. Replace every detail with your own true experience.

Behavioral (any employer)

Q: “Tell me about a time you made a mistake.”

Model answer: “In my last role I sent a client the wrong version of a pricing sheet, one that hadn’t been approved. I caught it an hour later when reconciling my sent folder. I called the client, explained, and sent the correct version with the changes highlighted. Then I told my manager before she heard it elsewhere. The client appreciated the transparency and signed that month. Afterward I added a ‘final’ folder and a two-minute pre-send check, and I haven’t repeated it since.”

Why it works: owns the mistake, shows fast action and honesty, ends with a system fix.

Q: “Why do you want to work remotely?”

Model answer: “I do my best work with focused blocks of time and clear written communication, and in my last role I already worked with a team across three time zones using Slack, Asana, and recorded updates. I keep a fixed schedule, I’m reachable during core hours, and I document my work so others don’t have to chase me for status.”

Why it works: frames remote work as a way of working, not a perk, and proves it with habits and tools.

Q (for laid-off candidates): “Why did you leave your last job?”

Model answer: “My position was one of [about 200] eliminated in a company-wide restructuring in [month]. I’m proud of what I delivered there, especially [one result]. I’m now focused on roles where I can [do the thing this job needs].”

Why it works: factual, brief, not defensive, and pivots to value. Do not criticize your former employer.

Customer service

Q: “A customer is shouting and demanding a manager. What do you do?”

Model answer: “First I let them finish, because interrupting escalates. Then I acknowledge the specific problem: ‘You were charged twice, and that’s not okay.’ I tell them what I can do right now and do it, for example starting the refund while they’re on the line. If they still want a manager, I offer it without taking it personally and give the manager a summary so the customer doesn’t have to repeat themselves. In my last job, using that approach, I resolved most escalations without a transfer.”

Why it works: a clear sequence, empathy plus action, and respect for policy.

AI-training / AI-interviewer screening

Q: "How would you decide which of two AI answers is better?"

Model answer: "I check them in priority order. First, is it accurate and safe? A wrong or harmful answer loses no matter how well written it is. Second, does it follow every instruction: format, length, audience? Third, is it complete and actually helpful for the user's real goal? Fourth, clarity and tone. I write my justification against those criteria and point to the exact sentence that decided it, so a reviewer can verify my reasoning."

Why it works: shows a rubric mindset, puts accuracy and safety first, and commits to verifiable justifications.

Q: "Explain a concept from your field to a non-expert." (expert roles)

Model answer structure: one-sentence definition → everyday analogy → one concrete example with a number → the most common misconception → why it matters. Keep it under 90 seconds. *Example (accounting): accrual vs. cash basis: "Cash basis records money when it moves; accrual records it when it's earned or owed..."*

Freelance client discovery call

Q (client): "We just need a website. How much?"

Model answer: "Happy to give you a number. Three quick questions so it's accurate: what's the main thing you want visitors to do: call, book, or buy? Roughly how many pages, and do you already have the text and photos? And is there a date this needs to be live? For a 5-page site with a booking form on [platform], projects like this usually land between $[X] and $[Y]. I'll send a fixed quote with exactly what's included by tomorrow."

Why it works: asks scoping questions before pricing, anchors a range, and commits to a written quote.

Startup founder interview

Q: "What would you do in your first 30 days here?"

Model answer: "Week one, I'd learn the product as a customer and read the last 50 support tickets or sales calls to hear how users describe the problem. Week two, I'd take ownership of one recurring task end to end, such as onboarding new customers, and document how I do it. Weeks three and four, I'd propose one small improvement with a metric, for example cutting first-response time, and ship it. I'd send you a short written update every Friday."

Why it works: startups want bias to action, customer focus, and self-direction.

AI video interview tips (one-way and AI-led)

- **Setup:** camera at eye level, light in front of you, plain background, a wired connection or a strong Wi-Fi spot. Close all other apps.
- **Look at the lens**, not your own image.
- **Pause two seconds** before answering. AI interviewers do not penalize brief thinking time the way people sometimes do.
- **Answer the actual question first**, then add detail. Many AI interviewers transcribe and evaluate content, so specific terms and numbers matter.
- **Use the practice round** if one is offered (Mercor offers one). Retake *before* submitting if allowed, but not endlessly: your first strong attempt is usually your best.
- **Expect follow-ups** on your resume. Know every line.
- **Check the consent terms.** Some platforms record interviews and share them with clients.

The improvement loop (20 minutes a day)

1. **Pick a mode** in P14 (rotate: behavioral → AI screening → role-specific).
2. **Answer 3 questions aloud,** recording audio or video on your phone.
3. **Score yourself** with the rubric, and paste the transcript for AI feedback.
4. **Rewrite one answer** using the feedback, keeping it true.
5. **Re-record it.** Aim for under 2 minutes with fewer fillers.
6. **Add the improved story** to your STAR bank (Workbook).

Daily: 20 minutes of P14 practice, out loud.

Before any AI interview: know every resume line and prepare 3 project stories with numbers.

Before any human interview: research the company, prepare 2 questions about the team's priorities, and follow up within 24 hours.

CHAPTER 11

LinkedIn & Networking That Leads to Real Openings

> **In this chapter:** how to find the recruiters, hiring managers, alumni, founders, and employees connected to the jobs you want; how to reach out, hold coffee chats, and ask for referrals without being awkward; and how to follow up. It includes 17 copy-ready templates and a 7-day networking plan. Remote roles are heavily contested (8.4% of LinkedIn postings drew 42% of applications), and the documented successes in Chapter 6 lean on networks and recruiter contact.

Step 1: Make your profile searchable (60 minutes, once)

Run prompt **P08**, then check:

- ☐ **Headline** names the target role and specialty, not just "Seeking opportunities." *Example:* "Customer Success & Onboarding | B2B SaaS | Zendesk, HubSpot | Open to remote roles"
- ☐ **Open to Work** is set. Choose *recruiters only* (visible to people using LinkedIn Recruiter) if you prefer privacy, or the public green banner. LinkedIn says it tries to hide the signal from your current employer but cannot guarantee it.
- ☐ **About** opens with your value in two lines and includes 8–10 keywords.
- ☐ **Experience** bullets match your resume, with numbers.
- ☐ **Skills**: the top 10 skills recruiters search for in your target role.
- ☐ **Location** is your real city or metro. Many remote roles are limited to certain states.
- ☐ A **professional photo** and a custom URL (linkedin.com/in/firstlast).

Step 2: Find the right people

For a specific job posting

1. Open the posting. Look for **"Meet the hiring team"** or the person who posted it.
2. Go to the company page → **People** → search the team name ("customer success," "data").
3. Identify: **(a)** the likely hiring manager (a team lead or manager title in that function), **(b)** the recruiter (a "Talent Acquisition," "Recruiter," or "People" title), and **(c)** 1–2 people currently in the role.

Alumni (one of the warmest cold contacts)

Go to your school's LinkedIn page → **Alumni** (linkedin.com/school/[your-school]/people/). Filter by **where they work**, **what they do**, and **where they live**. Alumni at target companies are among the most likely strangers to answer you.

LinkedIn search operators (people search)

Goal	Search string
Recruiters at a company	`"technical recruiter" OR "talent acquisition"` + Current company filter
Hiring managers for a function	`("customer success manager" OR "head of support") AND remote`
People in your target role	`"AI trainer" OR "data annotator" OR "RLHF"`
Founders of AI startups	`founder AND ("YC" OR "Y Combinator") AND AI`
Exclude noise	`recruiter NOT "staffing"`

LinkedIn supports quotation marks, AND, OR, NOT, and parentheses in search. Combine them with the **Current company**, **Location**, and **School** filters.

Google "X-ray" search (works without LinkedIn filters)

```
site:linkedin.com/in "recruiter" "Company Name"
site:linkedin.com/in "customer success" "Company Name" "University of X"
```

Founders and startup teams

- **YC Work at a Startup** and **Wellfound** list founders by name on company pages.
- Founders often post hiring needs on LinkedIn and X. Search "we're hiring" plus your role, and set the date filter to "past week."

Step 3: Reach out (the 3-part message)

Every outreach message has **one specific detail** (why them), **one sentence about you** (why it matters to them), and **one easy ask** (yes/no, 15 minutes, or "who should I talk to?").

> **Note on limits:** free LinkedIn accounts may cap how many personalized connection notes you can send each month. If you hit the cap, connect without a note and send your message once they accept, or reach out by email if their address is public.

17 outreach templates

Replace every [bracket]. Keep connection notes under 300 characters. Personalize the first line every time; a template that looks like a template gets ignored.

T1: Recruiter, specific opening (connection note)

> Hi [Name], I just applied for the [Role] (job ID [#]) on your team. I've spent [X years] doing [closest relevant work], most recently [one result]. Happy to share anything that helps your review. Thanks!

T2: Recruiter, follow-up after connecting

> Thanks for connecting, [Name]. For the [Role] opening: the posting emphasizes [must-have]. In my last role I [proof point with number]. My resume is in the system under [email]. Is there anything else useful for me to know about the process or timeline?

T3: Hiring manager, applied already

> Hi [Name], I saw you're hiring a [Role]. I applied today. I noticed your team [specific detail: launched X / posted about Y]. I've done similar work: [one-line result]. If it's helpful, I'd welcome 15 minutes to learn what success looks like in the first 90 days.

T4: Hiring manager, no posting yet

> Hi [Name], I've followed [Company]'s work on [specific]. I'm a [role] with experience in [skill] and I'm exploring remote roles on teams like yours. Are you expecting to grow the team this year? If so, I'd love to stay on your radar.

T5: Employee in the target role (informational chat)

> Hi [Name], I'm exploring [Role] roles and your path from [their past role] to [current] caught my eye. Would you be open to a 15-minute chat about what the work is like at [Company]? Happy to work around your schedule.

T6: Alumni

> Hi [Name], fellow [School] alum ([your year/major]) here. I'm moving into [field] and saw you're at [Company]. Would you have 15 minutes in the next couple of weeks to share how you got started? I'd really appreciate it.

T7: Former colleague, reconnecting after a layoff

> Hi [Name], it's been a while since [shared project]! Quick update: my role at [Company] was eliminated in a restructuring, and I'm looking for [target role], ideally remote. If you hear of anything, or know someone I should talk to, I'd be grateful. How are things with you?

T8: Asking for a referral (after a conversation)

> Thanks again for the chat last week, [Name]. It confirmed [Company] is where I'd like to be. There's an open [Role] (link) that matches what we discussed about [team need]. Would you be comfortable referring me? I've attached a 3-line summary you can paste, and no pressure at all if it's not a fit.
>
> *Summary:* [Name], [X years] in [skill]; [result 1]; [result 2]; applying for [Role/ID].

T9: Startup founder

> Hi [Name], I've been using/reading about [Product] and [specific observation]. I'm a [role] who has [relevant result]. If you're hiring for [function], I'd love to help. Here's a 1-page idea for [small improvement]: [link]. Open to a quick call?

T10: AI-training / expert work outreach (to an AI startup's ops or recruiting lead)

> Hi [Name], I'm a [credential, e.g., licensed CPA / PhD in molecular biology] with [X years] in [sub-field]. I've seen [Company] recruiting domain experts for model evaluation. I'd be glad to help on [domain] projects. I applied via [portal] on [date]. Is there a specific listing I should target?

T11: Freelance prospect (cold, with a specific fix)

> Hi [Name], I noticed [specific issue: your booking link on the Services page returns an error / your newsletter signup isn't connected]. I fix things like this for [type of business]. Here's a 2-minute video showing the fix: [link]. Want me to handle it this week for $[X]?

T12: Former client or manager, asking for a testimonial or recommendation

> Hi [Name], I'm building my freelance practice in [service]. Would you be willing to write 2–3 sentences about the [project] we did together for my LinkedIn or Upwork profile? I can draft something for you to edit if that's easier.

T13: Thank-you after a coffee chat (send within 24 hours)

> Thank you for your time today, [Name]. Your point about [specific insight] was especially helpful, and I'm going to [action you'll take]. I'll keep you posted on how it goes.

T14: Follow-up, no response (5–7 days later)

> Hi [Name], just bumping this in case it got buried. Totally understand if now isn't a good time. If someone else on the team is better to ask about [Role/topic], I'd appreciate a pointer.

T15: Follow-up after interview (24 hours)

> Thank you for speaking with me about the [Role], [Name]. I enjoyed discussing [topic]. It reinforced my interest, particularly [specific]. One thing I didn't mention: [brief extra proof point]. I look forward to next steps.

T16: Status check after interview (if past the promised date)

> Hi [Name], I hope your week is going well. I wanted to check on the timeline for the [Role]. I'm still very interested, and happy to provide anything else you need.

T17: Staying in touch after a rejection

> Thank you for letting me know, [Name]. I appreciated learning about [Company]'s work on [topic]. If another [role type] opens up, I'd love to be considered, and I'll keep following the team's progress.

Prompt **P18** personalizes any of these from a profile you paste in. **P19** prepares you for the coffee chat.

Coffee chats that turn into referrals

Structure for a 20-minute call:

1. **(2 min)** Thank them; give a 30-second intro (who you are, what you're targeting).
2. **(12 min)** Ask about *them and their team*: "What does a great first 90 days look like on your team?" · "What skills are hardest to hire for?" · "How does hiring usually work here: referrals, recruiters, postings?" · "What do you wish you'd known before joining?"
3. **(4 min)** Connect your experience to one thing they said.
4. **(2 min)** Ask: "Is there anyone else you'd suggest I talk to?" If there is an open role and the chat went well: "Would it be appropriate to mention our conversation when I apply?"
5. **Send the T13 thank-you within 24 hours.** If you apply, send T8 with a ready-to-paste summary.

Do: be on time, keep to time, take notes, and research their profile. **Don't:** ask for a job in the first minute, send your resume unasked, or "pick their brain" for an hour.

Networking around real openings: the 3-touch sequence

For each high-priority posting:

Day	Action
0	Apply (tailored, Chapter 9). Send T1 to the recruiter and T3 to the hiring manager.
1–2	Message 1–2 people in the role (T5) or alumni at the company (T6).
5–7	Follow up once (T14) if there's no reply.
After a chat	Ask for a referral (T8) if appropriate.
After an interview	T15 within 24 hours; T16 if a promised date passes.

7-day networking action plan

Day	Goal	Actions (≈60–90 min/day)	Output
1	Profile ready	Run P08; update headline, About, skills; turn on Open to Work	Searchable profile
2	Target list	List 15 target companies; for each, find 1 recruiter, 1 hiring manager, 1 employee or alum	45-person list in Workbook
3	Warm network	Send T7 to 10 former colleagues/managers; post a short "I'm looking for [role]" update	10 messages + 1 post
4	Live openings	Find 5 postings from the last 72 hours at target companies; apply; send T1 + T3 for each	5 applications, 10 messages

Day	Goal	Actions (≈60–90 min/day)	Output
5	Informational chats	Send T5/T6 to 10 employees/alumni; book 2–3 chats	10 messages
6	Founders & AI startups	Send T9/T10 to 5 founders or AI-startup ops leads; apply to 2 YC/Wellfound roles	5 messages, 2 applications
7	Follow-up & review	Send T14 to non-responders from Days 3–4; run P20 on your pipeline; plan next week	Updated pipeline

Benchmarks: response rates vary widely. Warm contacts and alumni typically reply far more often than cold recruiters. Track your own rates in the Workbook, and if a message type gets no replies after 15–20 sends, rewrite it.

Weekly target: 25–30 personalized messages, 3 coffee chats, 5–10 tailored applications.

Best contacts: former colleagues, alumni, people currently in the role, and the recruiter on a fresh posting.

Always: one specific detail, one easy ask, one polite follow-up.

CHAPTER 12

Get Working: The 7-Day and 30-Day Action Plans

In this chapter: two tracks you run **at the same time**. Track 1, *Urgent Income*, puts legitimate applications and paid gigs in motion within 7 days. Track 2, *Stable Employment*, runs a targeted, network-driven 30-day search for a salaried remote role. Neither guarantees a job or a specific income. Together they maximize your chances and reduce the time you go without pay. Printable trackers are in `ACTION_WORKBOOK.pdf`.

Before you start (Day 0, 60 minutes)

- ☐ If laid off: file for **unemployment insurance** in your state (CareerOneStop UI finder) and book an **American Job Center** appointment.
- ☐ Open a separate savings "tax bucket" for 1099 income (set aside 25–30%).
- ☐ Set up **PayPal** (verified, legal name) and confirm a US bank account for Stripe/ACH payouts.
- ☐ Create a free professional email (firstname.lastname@...) and a job-search folder in Google Drive.
- ☐ Copy the **Application Tracker** and **Income Tracker** from the Workbook.
- ☐ Decide your weekly hours: Track 1 ___ hrs · Track 2 ___ hrs (suggested 50/50 if you have no income, 30/70 if you do).

Track 1: Urgent Income (7 days)

Goal: start 6–10 legitimate applications and at least 2 paid-work channels, and have a sellable service live by Day 7. The first payments typically arrive days to weeks later, depending on platform payout schedules (Chapter 2).

Day	Focus	Actions	Done when
1	Generalist AI training + studies	Apply: **DataAnnotation** (take Starter Assessment when rested), **Outlier** (complete onboarding), **Prolific**, **UserTesting**. Verify ID where asked.	4 accounts created; DataAnnotation assessment scheduled or done

Day	Focus	Actions	Done when
2	Expert or W-2 route	*Professionals:* apply to 2–3 **Mercor** listings in your field (practice interview first), **Alignerr**, **micro1**; create a **GLG** profile. *Grad students:* **Handshake AI Fellowship**. *Beginners:* apply to **TELUS** US listing and 2 W-2 customer-service roles in your state (Amazon, Apple, Concentrix, TTEC).	3–5 applications
3	Package one existing skill	Choose a narrow offer (Chapter 8). Build 2 portfolio samples. Draft profile with P09.	Offer sentence + 2 samples
4	Go live on a marketplace	Publish your **Upwork** profile (or **Fiverr** gig, or **Contra**). Send 3–5 proposals on posts from the last 24 hours (P12).	Profile live; 3–5 proposals
5	Warm-network cash	Send T7 to 10 former colleagues/managers offering your service or asking for short-term contract leads. Apply on **Respondent** and **User Interviews**.	10 messages; 2 study applications
6	Assessments & interviews	Complete any pending AI interviews or qualification exams. Run P14/P16 practice first. Send 3–5 more proposals.	All pending assessments done
7	Review & stack	Log every application and payout. Run P20. Keep the channels that responded; drop or fix the rest. Schedule next week.	Updated tracker; next-week plan

Daily minimums (Track 1): 2 freelance proposals · check AI-training dashboards twice · claim any available studies/tests · log everything.

Realistic expectations. Many readers will see small payments in the first weeks: studies, tests, the first AI-training tasks. Acceptance decisions may take up to several weeks, and some platforms will never reply. If after 3 weeks you have no responses from a channel, change the approach (profile, niche, or platform) rather than repeating it.

Track 2: Stable Employment (30 days)

Goal: a tailored application pipeline of 25–40 high-fit remote roles, 30+ networking conversations started, interview readiness, and disciplined follow-up. In one large 2025 dataset the median time to a first offer was about 68 days, so this 30-day plan is the first leg, not the finish line.

Week 1: Foundation

- Define 1–2 target roles and 15 target companies (remote-friendly, hiring in your function).

- Build your master resume and LinkedIn (P03, P07/P08). Turn on Open to Work.
- Run the **7-day networking plan** (Chapter 11).
- Set job alerts: LinkedIn (Remote filter, past 24 hours), Indeed, We Work Remotely, Remotive, Wellfound, YC Work at a Startup, Handshake (students).
- **Output:** 5 tailored applications, 45-person contact list, 25 messages sent.

Week 2: Targeted applications + conversations

- 8–10 tailored applications using the 45-minute workflow. **Quality over volume:** fit score ≥ 6/10 (P02).
- Use the 3-touch sequence on every application (apply → recruiter + hiring manager → employee/alum).
- Hold 2–3 coffee chats; send thank-yous within 24 hours.
- Daily 20-minute interview practice (P14).
- **Output:** 13–15 total applications, 2–3 chats, 10+ follow-ups.

Week 3: Interview readiness + referrals

- Build an 8-story STAR bank (P15). Run mock interviews for each target role type.
- Ask for referrals after good conversations (T8).
- 8–10 new tailored applications; follow up on Week 1 applications (T14).
- **Output:** 21–25 total applications, at least 1 referral request, STAR bank complete.

Week 4: Follow-up, refine, convert

- Run P20 on your pipeline: which channels produced replies, screens, interviews?
- Double down on what worked (e.g., alumni intros, a specific job board); fix or drop what didn't.
- 8–10 more applications; send T16 status checks where dates have passed.
- Prepare negotiation notes (P17) for any offer.
- **Output:** 30–40 total applications, a funnel review, next-month plan.

Weekly scorecard (target vs. actual)

Metric	Weekly target	Wk 1	Wk 2	Wk 3	Wk 4
Tailored applications	8–10				
Personalized outreach messages	25				
Coffee chats held	2–3				
Referral requests	1–2				
Recruiter screens	track				
Interviews	track				
Mock-interview sessions	5				
Follow-ups sent	all due				
Income received (Track 1)	track				

Diagnosing a stalled search

Symptom after 3–4 weeks	Likely cause	Fix
No responses to applications	Weak fit, late applications, or resume parsing issues	Apply within 72 hours; fit ≥ 6/10; plain-text PDF test; add referrals
Recruiter screens but no interviews	Unclear story or salary mismatch	Tighten 60-second pitch; research ranges; P14 recruiter-screen mode
Interviews but no offers	Answers lack specifics; weak follow-up	STAR bank with numbers; T15 within 24 hours; ask for feedback
AI-training acceptances but no tasks	Generalist queue saturation	Apply to expert listings; add 2 more platforms; keep freelance track
Freelance profile views but no hires	Generic offer or proposals	Narrow niche; rewrite first line of proposals; add matching samples
Burnout	Too many low-fit applications	Cut volume, raise fit threshold, schedule rest days

A sample weekly schedule (20–25 hours)

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri
9:00–10:30	Applications (2)	Applications (2)	Applications (2)	Applications (2)	Pipeline review (P20)
10:30–11:30	Outreach (6 msgs)	Outreach (6)	Outreach (6)	Outreach (6)	Follow-ups
11:30–12:00	Interview practice	Interview practice	Interview practice	Interview practice	Interview practice
1:00–3:00	AI-training tasks / freelance work	AI-training / freelance	Coffee chats	AI-training / freelance	Skill-building or portfolio

Run both tracks. Income now buys time for the right job later.

Measure weekly. Keep what produces replies; change what doesn't.

No promises: legitimate work takes time. This plan removes guesswork, not uncertainty.

Appendix A: Full Opportunity Directory

All 71 entries, with roles, requirements, pay, application steps, payment terms, evidence of worker outcomes, challenges, strategies, and sources. Verified October 22, 2026. The same data is in `OPPORTUNITY_DIRECTORY.csv`.

A. AI Training & AI Startups

OD001 · Mercor

Status: Apply Now · Expert AI training marketplace

Apply: https://work.mercor.com

Roles & tasks: Hourly contracts writing, grading and red-teaming AI outputs in a domain (law, finance, medicine, STEM, software, writing, audio, operations); some concierge/ops roles

Beginner-friendly: Some (generalist and writing roles exist; best fit is proven domain experience)

US eligibility: Yes (many listings US/UK/CA; check each listing)

Requirements: Resume that clearly shows domain expertise; quiet room, webcam and mic for AI interview; some roles need degrees/licenses

Evidence strength: Strong

Published pay: Listings seen: Expert Model Trainer $50–140/hr; Concierge AI Trainer (US) $65–75/hr; Training & Development Specialist $60–110/hr (US/UK/CA, min 15 h/wk). BI reported a follow-on project at $16/hr *(source: Official listings + aggregator copies + Business Insider)*

Application steps: Create profile and upload resume → ~20-min AI video interview based on your resume (practice interview available; retakes allowed before submitting) → role-specific assessment or form → sometimes human call → contract and onboarding

Payment & fees: No application fee. Hourly contractors paid weekly via Stripe to a bank account in your own name (official docs). 1099 contractor: no tax withholding

Worker outcomes: Indeed reviewers praise weekly pay; WSJ/BI report 30,000+ contractors hired in 2025; BI documented pay cut on follow-on project; Blind/Indeed report long silences after interview

Challenges: Ghosting after AI interview; projects end early; pay varies by project; time tracking; LLM use on tasks is prohibited and grounds for removal

Success strategies: Apply to the narrowest listing that matches your verifiable expertise; rehearse a 60-second walk-through of each resume project; take the practice interview; reuse a strong completed interview across listings

Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5 · 6

OD002 · DataAnnotation

Status: Apply Now · AI training & RLHF (Surge AI crowd brand, reported)

Apply: https://www.dataannotation.tech

Roles & tasks: Write prompts, compare and rate chatbot answers, fact-check, coding evaluation, specialist (math, science, law) tracks

Beginner-friendly: Yes (generalist track requires strong English writing and reasoning, no degree)

US eligibility: Yes

Requirements: US/UK/CA/AU/NZ residency (reported); excellent written English; careful reasoning; coding track needs real coding skill

Evidence strength: Strong

Published pay: Generalist from ~$20+/hr; coding/specialist ~$40/hr and up (FAQ as quoted by multiple 2026 reviews; job board shows higher ranges for technical roles) *(source: Third-party reviews quoting official FAQ/job board)*

Application steps: Apply on site → one-time Starter Assessment (~1 hr, unpaid, no retake) → silent wait (days to ~4 weeks) → acceptance email → paid qualifications → projects appear on dashboard

Payment & fees: No fee. PayPal; hourly work reportedly payable ~7 days after submission, per-task ~3 days (community FAQ)

Worker outcomes: Indeed 4.1/5 (1,477 reviews, Jun 2026), Glassdoor 4.1/5; reviewers report prompt pay; others report no reply to assessment or sudden account closures; class action alleges misclassification (unproven)

Challenges: Single-shot assessment; no rejection notice; project dry spells; account closures without explanation

Success strategies: Take the assessment when rested; write complete, sourced, well-structured answers; never use AI to write answers; complete every qualification offered after acceptance

Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5

OD003 · Outlier (Scale AI)

Status: Apply Now · AI training & RLHF

Apply: https://outlier.ai/experts/all

Roles & tasks: Generalist writing/rating, domain expert tasks (STEM, medicine, law, coding), multilingual and audio projects

Beginner-friendly: Yes for generalist projects (availability uneven)

US eligibility: Yes

Requirements: Pass skill screening and ID verification; project-specific onboarding

Evidence strength: Strong

Published pay: Generalist listings advertise up to ~$15/hr; contributor-reported $12–30/hr standard work; expert pages advertise higher (e.g., up to $50/hr for some domains). Pay varies by verified country *(source: Official expert pages + third-party reviews)*

Application steps: Create account → choose expertise → skill screening (30–90 min general onboarding, unpaid) → identity verification → project onboarding and qualifiers (unpaid) → tasks

Payment & fees: No fee. Weekly payments (processed Tuesdays) via PayPal, AirTM or ACH

Worker outcomes: Glassdoor 3.2/5; 2026 reviews cite interesting tasks but sudden deactivation; BI documented generalist rate cut from $50 to $15/hr; 2024 payment thread reports weekly arrivals plus some delays

Challenges: Empty queue (no tasks) for days/weeks; unpaid onboarding; opaque quality flags; rate changes

Success strategies: Treat as supplemental; finish onboarding fast and accurately; read guidelines twice; match PayPal name/details to profile; join several platforms in parallel

Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5

OD004 · Alignerr (Labelbox)

Status: Apply Now · Expert AI training

Apply: https://job-boards.greenhouse.io/alignerr

Roles & tasks: Domain-expert AI training (STEM, coding in many languages, writing), human preference ranking, code evaluation

Beginner-friendly: Some (most listings want degrees or professional skill)

US eligibility: Yes

Requirements: Resume + ID verification; AI interview with 'Zara' for many roles; domain assessment (often one attempt)

Evidence strength: Medium

Published pay: AI Trainer (PhD) $30–150/hr for US-based (official listing); homepage reportedly cites ~$80/hr average; listings vary widely *(source: Official Greenhouse listing + third-party review)*

Application steps: Apply to a listing → ID verification → Zara AI interview (resume-specific) → domain assessment → contract/onboarding → project invitations

Payment & fees: No fee. Weekly or bi-weekly cycles reported; method depends on country

Worker outcomes: Trustpilot 2026: positives on tailored AI interview and responsive leads; negatives on unpaid removal after ~6 hrs, disputed ~$1.3k, rate cuts

Challenges: Approval ≠ work; payment disputes reported; one-attempt assessments

Success strategies: Apply only where your degree/skill matches exactly; prepare concrete resume stories for Zara; log your hours and task IDs for any dispute

Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5

OD005 · Handshake AI Fellowship (MOVE)

Status: Apply Now · AI training for students & graduates

Apply: https://joinhandshake.com/fellowship-program

Roles & tasks: Expert prompts, evaluation and reasoning tasks for frontier AI labs by academic field

Beginner-friendly: Yes for current/recent graduate students (master's/PhD) in any field

US eligibility: Yes

Requirements: US-based; master's/doctoral students, candidates or graduates; government ID verification; work authorization (visa rules: check current page)

Evidence strength: Medium

Published pay: $50–125/hr by education and expertise (official EDU-partner FAQ); individual listings e.g. $75–100/hr math *(source: Official FAQ + university career-office posting)*

Application steps: Sign up at fellowship page → upload resume, verify profile → government ID check → rolling review and matching → paid training exercise → project onboarding → tasking

Payment & fees: No fee. Weekly payouts via Stripe (third-party tracker)

Worker outcomes: Official pages describe paid onboarding and progression to reviewer roles; Rutgers AI Ethics Lab page documents a researcher working as a fellow; independent pay reports limited

Challenges: No guaranteed project; projects pause or end on short notice; removal if quality expectations not met

Success strategies: Ask your career office (many promote it); list thesis/research methods precisely; complete paid training exercise carefully

Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5

OD006 · micro1

Status: Apply Now · AI trainer marketplace + AI recruiter

Apply: https://jobs.micro1.ai

Roles & tasks: AI trainer & data annotator, software engineer AI trainer, domain experts, some full-time placements

Beginner-friendly: Some (generalist annotator listings; college-student listings seen)

US eligibility: Yes (listing-specific)

Requirements: AI interview with 'Zara' (camera, mic, screen); government ID

Evidence strength: Medium

Published pay: Official portal: AI Trainer & Data Annotator $20–98/hr; Software Engineer AI Trainer $30–80/hr; Indeed average ~$67/hr across 13 postings *(source: Official job portal + Indeed)*

Application steps: Browse opportunities portal → apply → Zara skill interview (30–60 min, reported no retakes) → ID verification → certified expert → contract offers

Payment & fees: No fee. Contractor; some reviewers say only active time is paid

Worker outcomes: Indeed 4.8/5 (130 reviews) praising flexibility; Glassdoor Mar 2026 reviewer got a low-rate generic contract despite high score

Challenges: Offered rate may be below listing max; project pauses

Success strategies: Apply to a specific listing (not just the general pool); answer interview questions with metrics; negotiate within the posted range

Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5

OD007 · TELUS Digital AI Community

Status: Apply Now · Search/ads/content rating, data collection

Apply: https://www.telusdigital.com/careers

Roles & tasks: Content reviewer, search/map rater, data collection and annotation, AI response assessment

Beginner-friendly: Yes

US eligibility: Yes

Requirements: Reside in US; pass qualification exam/training; one person per household; own computer

Evidence strength: Medium

Published pay: Content Reviewer – United States: est. $14/hr ($0.2333 per task), open to Nov 27, 2026; earlier US Rater listing $12–14/hr *(source: Job-board copies of TELUS listings)*

Application steps: Apply to country/language listing → profile verification → unpaid qualification exam (study guidelines) → onboarding → part-time self-scheduled work

Payment & fees: No fee — TELUS warns it never asks for deposits or 'Premium ID' fees. Independent contractor

Worker outcomes: Long-running program with many public listings; worker accounts on review sites mixed on hours cap and exam difficulty

Challenges: Rigorous unpaid exam; weekly hour caps; task-based pay means $/hr depends on speed

Success strategies: Study the rater guidelines like a test; practice on sample items; keep a quiet distraction-free block; ignore any 'recruiter' who asks for money

Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5

OD008 · Prolific

Status: Apply Now · Paid academic & AI research studies
Apply: https://www.prolific.com/participants
Roles & tasks: Surveys, experiments, AI evaluation studies, some specialist AI tasker pools
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes (waitlist possible)
Requirements: Reside in supported country (US supported); 18+; identity checks; may be waitlisted
Evidence strength: Strong
Published pay: Researchers must pay at least $8/hr; Prolific recommends $12/hr (official). Self-reported totals ~$150–500/month for active users *(source: Official help center + community self-reports)*
Application steps: Register → join waitlist if prompted → verify identity → complete 'About You' screeners thoroughly → claim studies as they appear
Payment & fees: No fee for participants; cash out via PayPal (new accounts have waiting periods between cash-outs, third-party)
Worker outcomes: r/beermoney Nov 2025 earnings threads list Prolific among top earners ($147–$360/month for some users)
Challenges: Waitlist; studies fill in minutes; small totals
Success strategies: Answer screeners honestly and completely; keep the tab open with notifications; never rush attention checks
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4

OD009 · Turing

Status: Apply Now · LLM coding & expert training contracts
Apply: https://www.turing.com/jobs
Roles & tasks: LLM coding evaluation (Python, JS, C++ and more), agent/function-call training, domain expert tasks
Beginner-friendly: No (developers and domain experts)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Coding skill verified by tests; AI interview; some roles US-based with Pacific-time overlap
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Turing recruiting page: $50–250/hr; listings $25–55/hr (LLM trainer) to $200–300/hr (senior dev) *(source: Official recruiting page + listings)*
Application steps: Profile → automated coding tests → AI-powered interview → practical assessment → matched to projects (no bidding)
Payment & fees: No fee. Monthly USD via Deel/Payoneer/bank; independent contractor
Worker outcomes: Many active listings; independent pay reports limited
Challenges: Assessments are demanding; matches not guaranteed
Success strategies: Prepare for timed coding tests; keep GitHub current; state hours/time-zone overlap clearly
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD010 · Invisible Technologies (Expert Marketplace / Meridial)

Status: Explore · Expert AI training
Apply: https://www.invisible.co
Roles & tasks: Freelance AI trainers by domain (writing, Python, finance, law, instructional design)
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes (listing-specific)
Requirements: Project-specific; own computer and fast internet; no visa sponsorship
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Listings: $8–65/hr by experience/location; specialist roles up to $150–200/hr (pay guide of ~800 listings) *(source: Third-party listing analysis)*
Application steps: Apply to listing → assessment → onboarding (details vary)
Payment & fees: Contractor, no benefits
Worker outcomes: Many listings; limited independent worker outcome data
Challenges: Wide pay range; listings close quickly
Success strategies: Apply only to listings with posted pay; confirm rate in writing
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD011 · Snorkel AI Expert Community

Status: Explore · Expert AI data
Apply: https://snorkel.ai/expert-community/
Roles & tasks: Expert contributors in law, medicine, STEM, computer science write and grade tasks
Beginner-friendly: No (advanced degrees common)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: US location for many listings; MD/DO for medical; JD for legal
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: $10–100 per high-quality task (law listing); $10–80 per submission (2025 listing) *(source: Official listings via job boards)*
Application steps: Apply via expert community → screening → project onboarding
Payment & fees: Independent contractor; payments via agent of record (third-party report)
Worker outcomes: Listings exist; independent outcome reports thin
Challenges: Per-task pay makes hourly rate uncertain
Success strategies: Time yourself on first tasks to compute real $/hr
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD012 · xAI — AI Tutor

Status: Explore · AI lab direct hire (temporary)
Apply: https://job-boards.greenhouse.io/xai
Roles & tasks: Full-time temporary AI tutor roles (STEM, bilingual, specialist)
Beginner-friendly: Some (specialists now preferred)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Device and smartphone requirements; ~6-month temporary roles; training 9:00–5:30 PST first 2 weeks
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: $35–65/hr in listings *(source: Listings (official Greenhouse + copies))*
Application steps: Apply on Greenhouse → assessments → interview → training period
Payment & fees: Full-time temp; medical insurance depending on residence
Worker outcomes: BI/Reuters: ≥500 generalist tutors laid off Sep 2025 as xAI pivoted to specialists
Challenges: Abrupt team changes; specialist bias
Success strategies: Apply for specialist roles matching your degree; have a backup income stream
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD013 · Mindrift (Toloka)

Status: Explore · AI tutor freelance
Apply: https://mindrift.ai
Roles & tasks: AI trainer writers, STEM/code specialists, journalists, designers
Beginner-friendly: Some (≥1 year professional experience, C1 English for writer roles)
US eligibility: Yes (listing-specific)
Requirements: Reside in listed country; CV review; short assessment; Persona ID check
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Advertised $15–100+/hr; typical generalist $15–30/hr; listing example $55/hr STEM *(source: Third-party reviews + listings)*
Application steps: Apply with CV → team review → short assessment → ID verification → matched when projects open
Payment & fees: No fee (official). Per-task pay; PayPal/Payoneer about twice monthly
Worker outcomes: Reviews describe regular payments with task droughts
Challenges: Waiting for project matching; per-task pay variance
Success strategies: Keep CV specific to domain; respond fast to project invites
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD014 · Welo Data (Welocalize)

Status: Explore · Search quality rating (W-2 part-time)
Apply: https://jobs.lever.co/weloglobal
Roles & tasks: Search quality rater, ads rater, translation validation
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes (state-limited listings)
Requirements: Reside in named states for some US listings; qualification exam
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Scout Search Quality Rater – English (US): $14.50/hr, W-2 part-time, paid every 2 weeks, 12-month project (Apr 2026 listing) *(source: Listing copy (Remotive))*
Application steps: Apply on Lever → screening → exam → onboarding
Payment & fees: W-2 (taxes withheld) for the US Scout listing
Worker outcomes: Long history of rater programs; limited 2026 worker reports
Challenges: State restrictions; hours vary
Success strategies: Filter Lever board for 'United States'; study rater guidelines
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD015 · RWS TrainAI

Status: Explore · Search evaluation & AI data
Apply: https://jobs.lever.co/rws
Roles & tasks: Search engine evaluator, AI data annotator, speech evaluation
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes (listing-specific)
Requirements: Qualification exam (unpaid, rigorous); 10–20 h/wk typical
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: US Search Engine Evaluator listing 'up to $15.8/hr' (Oct 2, 2026); blogs report $15–22/hr *(source: Listing copy + third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → exam → onboarding → hourly work
Payment & fees: Contractor; Tipalti payment complaints reported
Worker outcomes: Reviews report payment/support friction
Challenges: Exam failure rates; payment portal issues
Success strategies: Use as backup; keep records of invoices
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD016 · Appen (CrowdGen)

Status: Caution · Crowd AI data
Apply: https://crowdgen.com
Roles & tasks: Search/social evaluation, annotation, data collection
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile verification; project qualifications
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Not published centrally; reviews cite $10–20/hr industry averages *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Register on CrowdGen → verification → apply to projects → qualify
Payment & fees: No fee; bank/PayPal/Payoneer/Airtm
Worker outcomes: Indeed reviews (Apr–May 2026): little work available, pay timing issues; lost Google contract in 2024
Challenges: Low project volume
Success strategies: Register as a backup only
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD017 · OneForma (Centific)

Status: Caution · Crowd AI data
Apply: https://www.oneforma.com
Roles & tasks: Annotation, transcription, data collection
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes (project-specific)
Requirements: Multi-stage approval
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Reported $7–13/hr equivalent; transcription $0.50–1.25 per audio minute *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Register → profile → apply to jobs → qualifications (can take months)
Payment & fees: PayPal (reported $300/yr cap), Payoneer
Worker outcomes: Jun 2026 report: unresponsive support, postings down >60% late 2025
Challenges: Slow approval; low volume
Success strategies: Low priority
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD018 · Clickworker / UHRS

Status: Explore · Microtasks
Apply: https://www.clickworker.com
Roles & tasks: Microtasks: categorization, short writing, UHRS search judging
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: SSN + W-9 for US residents
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Effective $2–9/hr typical (third-party) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Register → assessments → tasks
Payment & fees: PayPal min €10 per official help; scheduled bill runs
Worker outcomes: Long-running; low earnings consistently reported
Challenges: Very low hourly
Success strategies: Only for gap-filling
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD019 · Remotasks

Status: Unavailable · Crowd AI data (Scale AI legacy)
Apply: https://outlier.ai
Roles & tasks: Legacy annotation platform; new sign-ups redirected to Outlier in tests
Beginner-friendly: n/a
US eligibility: Not verified (closure notice seen elsewhere)
Requirements: n/a
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: n/a *(source: n/a)*
Application steps: Use Outlier instead
Payment & fees: n/a
Worker outcomes: Closures in several countries (2024); Aug 2026 sign-up test showed closure notice pointing to Outlier
Challenges: Not open
Success strategies: Apply to Outlier
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD020 · Uber AI Solutions

Status: Explore · Gig AI data
Apply: https://www.uber.com/us/en/ai-solutions/
Roles & tasks: Coding validation, audio recording, image/video labeling; US driver pilot for in-app tasks
Beginner-friendly: Yes (pilot-based)
US eligibility: Partial (pilot)
Requirements: Program-specific; driver pilot via Uber app
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Not verified ($20–200/hr claim from a weak source) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Watch Uber app / AI Solutions page for invitations
Payment & fees: Not verified
Worker outcomes: Pilot reported Oct 2025; division leadership exits Jan & Jul 2026
Challenges: Limited access
Success strategies: Opportunistic only
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD021 · Y Combinator — Work at a Startup

Status: Apply Now · AI startup jobs (full-time, contract, intern)
Apply: https://www.workatastartup.com
Roles & tasks: Engineering, design, product, operations, sales, recruiting at YC-funded startups; remote filter available
Beginner-friendly: Some (new grads and interns welcome at many startups)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: One profile; founders reach out; you can also apply directly
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Salary and equity shown per listing (e.g., Halluminate roles $150–275K) *(source: Official listings)*
Application steps: Create one profile → set role/remote preferences → founders message you or you apply to listings → founder chats → work trial/interviews
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Official FAQ; widely used by YC companies; individual outcome reports limited in search index
Challenges: High competition for remote roles; many SF in-person roles
Success strategies: Write a specific 'what I've built' section; message founders with a 3-line note tied to their product
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD022 · Wellfound (formerly AngelList Talent)

Status: Apply Now · Startup job board
Apply: https://wellfound.com/candidates/remote
Roles & tasks: Startup roles across functions; remote filters; salary/equity shown before applying
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile + resume; check 'Hires remotely from' for each job
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Salary and equity ranges on listings *(source: Official listings)*
Application steps: Build profile → filter remote/US → apply with short note → recruiter chat
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Reviews: salary transparency praised; some users get few replies or spam
Challenges: Low response rate on popular remote roles
Success strategies: Apply within 48 hours of posting; personalize the note
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD023 · Halluminate (YC S25)

Status: Explore · AI startup (finance RL environments)
Apply: https://www.workatastartup.com/jobs/84521
Roles & tasks: Full-time SF roles; company recruits and trains 'contractor finance staff' (no public contractor application found)
Beginner-friendly: No
US eligibility: Yes (in-person SF for full-time)
Requirements: Finance analyst/associate background for project lead roles
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: $150–275K full-time (YC listings) *(source: Official YC listing)*
Application steps: 3 × 30-min video chats → 2-day in-person or 5-day remote work trial
Payment & fees: n/a
Worker outcomes: None public for contractors
Challenges: No open contractor route
Success strategies: Finance professionals: follow founders on LinkedIn/X and ask about contractor roles
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

B. Freelance & Project Marketplaces

OD024 · Upwork

Status: Apply Now · General freelance marketplace
Apply: https://www.upwork.com/nx/signup/?dest=home
Roles & tasks: Bid on client jobs or sell Project Catalog packages: writing, design, admin/VA, marketing, data, development, AI services
Beginner-friendly: Yes (slow start typical)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile approval; ID verification (often after first contract)
Evidence strength: Strong
Published pay: Freelancer sets rate. Fees: variable freelancer service fee 0–15% shown at proposal (third-party); Freelancer Plus $19.99/mo incl. 100 Connects and 0% service fee (Upwork pricing page) *(source: Official pricing page + third-party fee guides)*
Application steps: Sign up → complete profile (title, overview, portfolio, rate) → approval → buy/spend Connects on proposals → interview via chat/call → contract → milestones/hours
Payment & fees: Basic: 10 free Connects/mo, extra $0.15 each; withdraw to US bank
Worker outcomes: Upwork community: '2 months to first client', '6 months of proposals'; Upwork-quoted Reddit: profile July → first client October
Challenges: Connects cost; saturated categories; first review is hardest
Success strategies: Niche title; 2–3 portfolio pieces; apply within hours of posting; small fixed-price first jobs; specific 120–180 word proposals
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3 · 4

OD025 · Fiverr

Status: Apply Now · Gig (productized service) marketplace
Apply: https://www.fiverr.com/start_selling
Roles & tasks: Sell fixed-scope gigs: design, writing, video, voice, data, AI services, VA
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Seller profile, gigs with packages and samples
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Seller sets price; Fiverr keeps 20% of every order incl. tips *(source: Third-party fee guides citing ToS)*
Application steps: Create seller account → publish 1–3 gigs (packages, FAQ, gallery) → respond fast to inquiries → deliver → reviews unlock levels
Payment & fees: Earnings clear after ~14 days (7 for Top Rated); withdrawal fees vary
Worker outcomes: Fiverr community: first order after ~3 weeks; first order in a week then 3 months none; returning sellers struggle
Challenges: Visibility; 20% fee; price competition
Success strategies: Narrow gig ('Notion CRM setup for real-estate agents'); outcome-based title; fast response time; reuse buyers
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD026 · Contra

Status: Apply Now · Portfolio-first, commission-free
Apply: https://contra.com
Roles & tasks: Portfolio + service listings for design, development, marketing, content; invoices and contracts for clients you bring
Beginner-friendly: Yes (best for invoicing clients you find yourself)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Portfolio
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: 0% commission for freelancers (official); Pro $29/mo or $199/yr (third-party) *(source: Official + third-party)*
Application steps: Create profile → add projects and services → share link with leads → send proposals/invoices
Payment & fees: Bank, card, PayPal, USDC payouts; clients may pay fees
Worker outcomes: Reviews: job board thin without Pro
Challenges: Few inbound clients
Success strategies: Use as your portfolio + payment rail; bring clients from LinkedIn
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD027 · Freelancer.com

Status: Explore · Bidding marketplace + contests
Apply: https://www.freelancer.com/signup
Roles & tasks: Bid on projects; contests for design
Beginner-friendly: Yes (very price-competitive)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile; limited free bids
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Freelancer fee 10% or $5 minimum per project payment (Fees page as cited Jul 2026) *(source: Third-party citing official page)*
Application steps: Sign up → skills/exams → bid → award → milestone payments
Payment & fees: Membership tiers add bids
Worker outcomes: Limited recent US outcome data
Challenges: Low budgets; spam projects
Success strategies: Bid only on verified-payment clients; never move payment off-platform
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD028 · Toptal

Status: Apply Now · Vetted senior network
Apply: https://www.toptal.com/talent/apply
Roles & tasks: Developers, designers, finance experts, project/product managers on client engagements
Beginner-friendly: No (senior talent)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Strong English and communication; technical test; live screening; test project
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Talent sets hourly rate; Toptal does not publish markup *(source: Official)*
Application steps: Language & personality interview → timed skill test → live technical screening → test project (1–3 wks) → onboarding; total 3–8 weeks; <3% accepted (Toptal claim)
Payment & fees: No fee to talent
Worker outcomes: Long-running network; acceptance-rate claims self-reported
Challenges: Very selective
Success strategies: Apply only with 3+ years of strong, demonstrable work
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD029 · Braintrust

Status: Apply Now · Talent network with AI recruiter
Apply: https://www.usebraintrust.com/for-talent
Roles & tasks: Contract roles in engineering, design, product, marketing at enterprise clients
Beginner-friendly: No
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: AI interview (AIR); experience
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Talent keeps 100% (official: no talent fees) *(source: Official)*
Application steps: Create profile → AI screening interview → apply to jobs → client interviews
Payment & fees: Free to talent
Worker outcomes: Limited recent independent reports
Challenges: Competitive
Success strategies: Use for mid/senior contract roles
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD030 · Guru

Status: Explore · General marketplace
Apply: https://www.guru.com
Roles & tasks: Programming, writing, design, admin, engineering
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Job fee ~4.95–8.95% by membership plan *(source: Third-party citing pricing page)*
Application steps: Profile → quotes on jobs → SafePay agreements
Payment & fees: SafePay escrow
Worker outcomes: Limited recent data
Challenges: Lower traffic
Success strategies: Secondary profile
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD031 · PeoplePerHour

Status: Explore · UK-based marketplace (US accepted)
Apply: https://www.peopleperhour.com
Roles & tasks: Hourlies (fixed offers) and proposals
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile approval
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Fees: 20% on first £500 per client, then 7.5%, then 3.5% (third-party; tiers disputed) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → approval → proposals/hourlies
Payment & fees: GBP-centric
Worker outcomes: Limited US data
Challenges: UK client base
Success strategies: Good for UK/EU-facing services
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD032 · 99designs (Vista)

Status: Explore · Design contests & 1-to-1
Apply: https://99designs.com/designers
Roles & tasks: Logo, branding, packaging, web design contests and direct projects
Beginner-friendly: Yes (contests)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Portfolio; levels Entry/Mid/Top
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Contest prizes ~$249–1,300+; designer platform fee reported 15/10/5% by level *(source: Official help + third-party)*
Application steps: Sign up → enter contests → win/finalist → level reviews in application windows
Payment & fees: Level-based fees
Worker outcomes: Long-running; contests are speculative work
Challenges: Unpaid contest entries
Success strategies: Limit contest time; move winners to 1-to-1
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD033 · Arc.dev

Status: Apply Now · Remote developer network
Apply: https://arc.dev
Roles & tasks: Freelance and full-time remote developer roles
Beginner-friendly: No
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile screen, technical vetting, interviews
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Reported $60–80/hr for freelancers (third-party) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Profile → screen → technical interview → matching
Payment & fees: Free to developers
Worker outcomes: Limited
Challenges: Selective
Success strategies: Strong GitHub + clear stack
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD034 · MarketerHire

Status: Explore · Vetted marketing freelancers
Apply: https://marketerhire.com
Roles & tasks: Paid media, growth, content, lifecycle, SEO contracts
Beginner-friendly: No
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Work samples, skills assessment, video interview
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Not published *(source: n/a)*
Application steps: Apply → review of experience and samples → skills assessment → video interview
Payment & fees: Not published
Worker outcomes: Company claims <5% accepted
Challenges: Selective
Success strategies: Bring quantified campaign results
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD035 · Catalant

Status: Explore · Independent consulting marketplace
Apply: https://gocatalant.com
Roles & tasks: Strategy, operations, finance consulting projects for enterprises
Beginner-friendly: No
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Consulting/industry experience
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Not published *(source: n/a)*
Application steps: Expert profile → matched to project briefs
Payment & fees: Not published
Worker outcomes: Mixed freelancer sentiment on Trustpilot
Challenges: Few matches
Success strategies: For ex-consultants/managers
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD036 · GLG (Gerson Lehrman Group)

Status: Apply Now · Expert network — paid calls
Apply: https://glginsights.com
Roles & tasks: Paid 1-hour phone/video consultations with investors and consultants about your industry knowledge
Beginner-friendly: No (needs industry experience; laid-off professionals fit well)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Industry expertise; compliance training; confidentiality rules (no current-employer secrets)
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: You set/agree a per-call rate; advice sites estimate $100–300/hr typical *(source: Third-party estimates)*
Application steps: Create network member profile → wait for project invitations → screening questions → scheduled call
Payment & fees: Paid per consultation
Worker outcomes: Widely documented industry; volume unpredictable
Challenges: Irregular invitations
Success strategies: Detail niche expertise (products, vendors, regions) in profile; answer screening questions quickly
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD037 · AlphaSights / Guidepoint

Status: Explore · Expert networks
Apply: https://www.guidepoint.com
Roles & tasks: Paid expert calls and surveys
Beginner-friendly: No
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Industry experience
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Per-call; estimates $100–300/hr *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Usually invited via LinkedIn/email; Guidepoint accepts expert sign-ups
Payment & fees: Per consultation
Worker outcomes: Industry-wide
Challenges: Irregular
Success strategies: Keep LinkedIn headline specific to your niche
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD038 · Dribbble / Behance

Status: Explore · Design portfolios with job boards
Apply: https://www.behance.net
Roles & tasks: Portfolio hosting, freelance project inquiries, job boards
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Portfolio
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Not applicable (client-set) *(source: n/a)*
Application steps: Publish case studies → enable hire-me → respond to inquiries
Payment & fees: Platform payment fees vary by plan
Worker outcomes: Limited
Challenges: Passive inbound
Success strategies: Use as portfolio links in Upwork/LinkedIn outreach
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

C. Other Remote Jobs

OD039 · Amazon — Virtual Customer Service

Status: Explore · Customer service (W-2)
Apply: https://www.amazon.jobs/en/search?base_query=virtual+customer+service
Roles & tasks: Chat/phone customer service from home; seasonal and regular
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: State-limited
Requirements: Reside in a hiring state; reliable internet; quiet workspace
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: ~$15–19/hr reported; ZipRecruiter aggregate avg $18.80/hr *(source: Third-party/aggregate)*
Application steps: Apply only on amazon.jobs → assessment → virtual onboarding
Payment & fees: W-2 with benefits after waiting period (reported)
Worker outcomes: Large-scale past hiring pushes (e.g., 3,000 remote CS roles in 18 states)
Challenges: Openings appear in waves; scams impersonate Amazon
Success strategies: Set job alerts on amazon.jobs; never apply via text/WhatsApp links
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD040 · Apple — At Home Advisor

Status: Explore · Tech support (W-2)
Apply: https://jobs.apple.com/en-us/search?search=at%20home%20advisor
Roles & tasks: AppleCare phone/chat support; College Program variant for students
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes (location-limited)
Requirements: US residency in hiring area; home office setup
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: College Program At Home Advisor $27.75–32.45/hr (tech.co); ZipRecruiter aggregate avg $26.41 (Aug 2026) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Apply on jobs.apple.com → assessments → virtual interview → paid training
Payment & fees: W-2 employee
Worker outcomes: Glassdoor interview reports exist
Challenges: Seasonal openings
Success strategies: Search 'At Home Advisor' monthly
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD041 · Concentrix (work-at-home)

Status: Explore · Customer service BPO (W-2)
Apply: https://jobs.concentrix.com
Roles & tasks: Customer service, tech support, sales for client brands
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: State-limited
Requirements: Background check, internet speed test, state residency
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: ~$13–18/hr reported (2026) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → assessment → interview → paid training
Payment & fees: W-2
Worker outcomes: Large employer; reviews mixed
Challenges: Strict metrics
Success strategies: Filter careers site by 'remote' + your state
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD042 · TTEC @Home

Status: Explore · Customer service BPO (W-2)
Apply: https://careers.ttec.com
Roles & tasks: Customer care, tech support, sales
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: State-limited
Requirements: Background check; equipment/internet requirements
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: ~$15–18/hr reported; some reduced training rate *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → assessments → virtual interview → training
Payment & fees: W-2
Worker outcomes: Large employer
Challenges: Training-rate period
Success strategies: Ask about training pay in interview
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD043 · Foundever (formerly Sitel)

Status: Explore · Customer service BPO (W-2)
Apply: https://foundever.com/careers
Roles & tasks: Customer service and support
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: State-limited
Requirements: Internet speed check before offer; equipment often provided
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: ~$14–17/hr reported *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → speed check → assessment → interview → training
Payment & fees: W-2
Worker outcomes: Glassdoor reviews; one 2026 review ~$25/hr specific account
Challenges: Account-dependent schedules
Success strategies: Prioritize postings that ship equipment
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD044 · Liveops

Status: Caution · Customer service (independent contractor)
Apply: https://join.liveops.com
Roles & tasks: Inbound calls for client programs (insurance, healthcare, retail)
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: $25 background check paid by you; unpaid certification; dual monitors, wired internet; Windows PC
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Talk-time 25–34¢ per minute for some programs; some commission-only (official FAQ) *(source: Official)*
Application steps: Apply → pay background check → unpaid program certification → schedule calls
Payment & fees: Paid twice monthly; you cover equipment; no guaranteed earnings
Worker outcomes: Long-running; reviews note pay only while on calls
Challenges: Upfront costs; unpaid certification; only talk time paid
Success strategies: Calculate realistic $/hr before paying anything
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD045 · Arise

Status: Caution · Customer service (contractor via 'IBO')
Apply: https://www.arise.com
Roles & tasks: Customer service for client brands as an independent business
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Historically: paid training/certification and equipment
Evidence strength: Strong
Published pay: Not published *(source: n/a)*
Application steps: Register business → paid certification courses (historically) → client programs
Payment & fees: Worker-paid costs reported
Worker outcomes: ProPublica investigation; D.C. Attorney General lawsuit alleging misclassification and pay practices
Challenges: Pay-to-work model
Success strategies: Prefer W-2 customer service employers
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD046 · Working Solutions

Status: Explore · Customer service (contractor)
Apply: https://workingsolutions.com
Roles & tasks: Customer support, sales, tech support programs
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Program certification
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Not verified (~$15/hr listicle) *(source: Weak third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → assessment → program certification
Payment & fees: Contractor
Worker outcomes: Thin
Challenges: Unverified pay
Success strategies: Ask for program pay in writing before certifying
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD047 · BELAY

Status: Explore · Virtual assistant / bookkeeping (US contractors)
Apply: https://belaysolutions.com/careers/
Roles & tasks: Executive/virtual assistant, bookkeeping, web specialist for US small businesses
Beginner-friendly: No (admin experience expected)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: US-based; experience; vetting (claims top 2–3% accepted)
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Clients pay ~$42–50/hr; VA pay ~$20/hr in one anonymous report; BELAY says it raised specialist pay ≥53% in four years *(source: Third-party + Glassdoor)*
Application steps: Apply → assessments → interviews → client match
Payment & fees: 1099 contractor
Worker outcomes: Glassdoor reviews mixed (great flexibility; low end for EA)
Challenges: Wait for client match
Success strategies: Lead with admin tools you master (Google Workspace, QuickBooks, CRM)
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD048 · Wyzant

Status: Apply Now · Online tutoring marketplace
Apply: https://www.wyzant.com
Roles & tasks: 1-on-1 tutoring in academic subjects, test prep, professional skills
Beginner-friendly: Yes (subject mastery required)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile, subject quizzes, background check
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Tutors set rates; commission 25% until $2,000 earned, then 20% (third-party) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Profile → subject tests → approval → respond to student requests
Payment & fees: Commission per lesson
Worker outcomes: Widely used; outcomes depend on subject demand
Challenges: Starting without reviews
Success strategies: Price modestly at first; respond within an hour
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD049 · Varsity Tutors

Status: Explore · Assigned online tutoring
Apply: https://www.varsitytutors.com
Roles & tasks: Tutoring matched by algorithm
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Subject tests; background check
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: $15–40/hr; ~$15 most common (third-party) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → subject assessments → mock session → matching
Payment & fees: Contractor
Worker outcomes: Reviews note low base pay
Challenges: Low base rate
Success strategies: Use for quick start, move to own clients
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD050 · Tutor.com (Princeton Review)

Status: Explore · On-demand tutoring
Apply: https://www.tutor.com/apply
Roles & tasks: On-demand chat tutoring
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Subject exams; often college student or degree
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: $12–22/hr reported *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → exams → mock session → certification
Payment & fees: Contractor
Worker outcomes: Long-running
Challenges: Low pay
Success strategies: Quick-start option
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD051 · Rev

Status: Apply Now · Transcription & captioning
Apply: https://www.rev.com/freelancers
Roles & tasks: Transcription, captions, subtitles
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Grammar test + transcription sample
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: ~$0.30–1.10 per audio minute (third-party); effective hourly often low *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Apply → English/grammar test → transcription sample → claim jobs from queue
Payment & fees: PayPal weekly (reported)
Worker outcomes: Glassdoor Feb 2026: test easy, no feedback after assessment
Challenges: Low effective hourly; AI competition
Success strategies: Use for short-term income; aim for captioning
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2 · 3

OD052 · TranscribeMe

Status: Explore · Transcription
Apply: https://workhub.transcribeme.com
Roles & tasks: Short-clip transcription
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Training course + exam
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: $15–22 per audio hour (third-party) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Free training → exam → tasks
Payment & fees: PayPal
Worker outcomes: Long-running
Challenges: Very low hourly
Success strategies: Gap-filler only
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD053 · GoTranscript

Status: Explore · Transcription
Apply: https://gotranscript.com/transcription-jobs
Roles & tasks: Transcription
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Test
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Up to $0.60 per audio minute (third-party) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Test → tasks
Payment & fees: PayPal/Payoneer
Worker outcomes: Long-running
Challenges: Low hourly
Success strategies: Gap-filler only
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD054 · UserTesting

Status: Apply Now · Website/app feedback tests
Apply: https://www.usertesting.com/get-paid-to-test
Roles & tasks: Think-aloud tests (~$10 for 15–20 min), live interviews ($30–60)
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Practice test; mic; screen recorder
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: ~$10 per test; live interviews $30–60 (third-party) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Sign up → practice test → screeners → tests
Payment & fees: PayPal
Worker outcomes: Trustpilot: tests first-come-first-served; reward shown upfront
Challenges: Tests vanish fast
Success strategies: Enable notifications; speak continuously during tests
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD055 · Respondent

Status: Apply Now · Paid research interviews (professionals)
Apply: https://www.respondent.io
Roles & tasks: Paid user-research interviews, focus groups
Beginner-friendly: Yes (professional background helps)
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Verified LinkedIn/profile
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: $50–400+ per study (third-party) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Profile → apply to studies → screener → scheduled session
Payment & fees: Paid after session
Worker outcomes: Widely cited
Challenges: Low selection rate
Success strategies: Accurate job title and tools in profile
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD056 · User Interviews

Status: Apply Now · Paid research studies
Apply: https://www.userinterviews.com/studies
Roles & tasks: Interviews, surveys, usability studies
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Supported country (US supported)
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Per study (shown on listing) *(source: Official listings)*
Application steps: Sign up → apply to studies → screener
Payment & fees: Gift cards/PayPal
Worker outcomes: Official country list
Challenges: Selective screeners
Success strategies: Apply daily
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD057 · uTest (Applause)

Status: Explore · Crowdtesting
Apply: https://www.utest.com
Roles & tasks: Functional/usability testing; pay per approved bug
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Academy courses; devices
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Per bug/cycle; $5–50 per cycle commonly reported *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Sign up → academy → sandbox → invitations
Payment & fees: PayPal/Payoneer
Worker outcomes: Glassdoor: high competition; rejected bugs unpaid
Challenges: Pay-per-bug variance
Success strategies: Build QA skills to move to Testlio/QA jobs
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD058 · Testlio

Status: Explore · Freelance QA (hourly)
Apply: https://testlio.com/job/freelance-us-guam
Roles & tasks: Hourly software testing on client projects
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Technical screen + paid trial cycle
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Hourly; e.g., $18/hr listing (2025) *(source: Official listings)*
Application steps: Apply → screen → paid trial cycle → projects
Payment & fees: Weekly PayPal/Payoneer (reported)
Worker outcomes: Official network pledge; listings
Challenges: Country/device-specific projects
Success strategies: List your devices and OS versions
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD059 · LinkedIn Jobs

Status: Apply Now · Job board + network
Apply: https://www.linkedin.com/jobs/search/?f_WT=2
Roles & tasks: All functions; 'Remote' workplace filter (f_WT=2)
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Profile
Evidence strength: Strong
Published pay: Pay ranges shown on many US listings *(source: Official)*
Application steps: Filter Remote + date posted (past 24h/week) → apply → message poster/recruiter
Payment & fees: Free (Premium optional)
Worker outcomes: LinkedIn data: remote = 8.4% of postings but 42% of applications
Challenges: Huge competition on remote roles
Success strategies: Apply early, then message the hiring team; prefer referrals
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD060 · Indeed

Status: Apply Now · Job board
Apply: https://www.indeed.com/q-remote-jobs.html
Roles & tasks: All functions incl. remote customer service, admin, sales
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Resume
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Varies *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Search 'remote' + title → apply → assessments
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Largest US job board; scams present in listings
Challenges: Fake postings
Success strategies: Cross-check employer careers page before applying
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD061 · We Work Remotely

Status: Apply Now · Remote job board
Apply: https://weworkremotely.com
Roles & tasks: Programming, design, customer support, sales, marketing, management
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes (region filters incl. USA only)
Requirements: Varies
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Varies *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Filter region → apply on employer site
Payment & fees: Free for job seekers
Worker outcomes: Long-running remote board
Challenges: Senior-heavy tech roles
Success strategies: Use the Customer Support category for entry roles
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD062 · Remotive

Status: Apply Now · Remote job board
Apply: https://remotive.com/remote-jobs
Roles & tasks: Tech, support, marketing, AI training listings
Beginner-friendly: Some
Requirements: Varies
Published pay: Often listed *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Filter → apply on employer site
Payment & fees: Free (paid accelerator optional)
Worker outcomes: Carries many AI training listings cited in this guide
Challenges: Location restrictions
Success strategies: Read 'location' tag before applying
US eligibility: Yes (location tags per listing)
Evidence strength: Medium
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD063 · Himalayas

Status: Apply Now · Remote job board
Apply: https://himalayas.app/jobs/countries/united-states
Roles & tasks: Remote roles with company profiles
Beginner-friendly: Some
Requirements: Free profile
Published pay: Often listed *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Filter by US → apply
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Limited
Challenges: Duplicates of other boards
Success strategies: Use country filter
US eligibility: Yes
Evidence strength: Weak
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD064 · Remote OK

Status: Explore · Remote job board
Apply: https://remoteok.com
Roles & tasks: Remote tech and non-tech roles
Beginner-friendly: Some
Requirements: Varies
Published pay: Often listed *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Filter → apply
Payment & fees: Free for seekers
Worker outcomes: Frequently updated (review)
Challenges: Tech-heavy
Success strategies: Sort by highest paid / newest
US eligibility: Yes
Evidence strength: Weak
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD065 · Working Nomads

Status: Explore · Remote job aggregator
Apply: https://www.workingnomads.com/jobs
Roles & tasks: Curated remote jobs
Beginner-friendly: Some
Requirements: Varies
Published pay: Varies *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Filter → apply
Payment & fees: Free board; premium optional
Worker outcomes: Limited
Challenges: Expired listings
Success strategies: Check listing date
US eligibility: Yes
Evidence strength: Weak
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD066 · Dynamite Jobs

Status: Explore · Remote job board
Apply: https://dynamitejobs.com
Roles & tasks: Remote roles at bootstrapped companies (ops, VA, marketing)
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Varies
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Salary shown on listings *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Apply via listing
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Limited
Challenges: Smaller volume
Success strategies: Good for ops/VA roles
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD067 · Built In

Status: Explore · Tech job board
Apply: https://builtin.com/jobs/remote
Roles & tasks: Tech company roles incl. remote; carries AI training listings
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Varies
Evidence strength: Weak
Published pay: Often listed *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Filter remote → apply
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Limited
Challenges: Tech-centric
Success strategies: Combine with company research
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD068 · Handshake (student & new-grad jobs)

Status: Apply Now · Early-career job platform
Apply: https://joinhandshake.com
Roles & tasks: Internships, entry-level remote roles, virtual career fairs
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Student/alum account (many schools partner)
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Varies *(source: Listings)*
Application steps: Log in via school → filter Remote → apply → attend virtual fairs
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Primary early-career channel at partner schools
Challenges: Volume of applicants
Success strategies: Message employers after virtual fairs
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1

OD069 · FlexJobs

Status: Caution · Paid, hand-screened remote board
Apply: https://www.flexjobs.com
Roles & tasks: Screened remote/flexible listings
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: Paid subscription
Evidence strength: Medium
Published pay: Subscription: $2.95 14-day trial auto-renewing ~$23.95/4 weeks; quarterly ~$29.85; annual ~$71.40 (third-party, varies) *(source: Third-party)*
Application steps: Subscribe → search → apply on employer site
Payment & fees: Watch auto-renewal
Worker outcomes: Users flag renewal visibility
Challenges: Cost; many listings also free elsewhere
Success strategies: Use free boards first; if you subscribe, set a cancel reminder
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD070 · USAJOBS (federal)

Status: Caution · Federal government jobs
Apply: https://www.usajobs.gov
Roles & tasks: Federal roles; remote now rare
Beginner-friendly: Some
US eligibility: Yes (citizenship often required)
Requirements: Federal resume format
Evidence strength: Strong
Published pay: GS pay scales on listings *(source: Official)*
Application steps: Profile → federal resume → questionnaire → referral → interview
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Jan 2025 executive order ended most federal remote work; hiring freeze → targeted 2026 thaw (10,475 open positions Feb 24, 2026)
Challenges: Few remote roles; long timelines
Success strategies: Look for 'Remote job: Yes' only from agencies hiring now; don't rely on it for urgent income
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

OD071 · CareerOneStop / American Job Centers

Status: Apply Now · Free public reemployment services
Apply: https://www.careeronestop.org/WorkerReEmployment/
Roles & tasks: Unemployment insurance finder, ~2,300 local American Job Centers, resume help, training funds, state job banks
Beginner-friendly: Yes
US eligibility: Yes
Requirements: None for self-service; some programs need eligibility
Evidence strength: Strong
Published pay: Free services *(source: Official (U.S. DOL))*
Application steps: Use Worker ReEmployment site → file UI in your state → book an American Job Center appointment
Payment & fees: Free
Worker outcomes: Official federal program
Challenges: Mostly self-service
Success strategies: Ask about WIOA-funded training and free LinkedIn Learning access
Verified: 2026-10-22 · Sources: 1 · 2

Appendix B: Worker Evidence Table

51 documented items. Types: OFFICIAL, JOURNALISM, DATA, REVIEWS, ANECDOTE (see Chapter 6). The same data, with more columns, is in `WORKER_SUCCESS_RESEARCH.csv`.

ID	Platform	Type	Pattern	What happened	Lesson	Src
WS001	Mercor	OFFICIAL	PROCESS	AI interview is ~20 min, camera on, quiet room; free practice interview; can redo the AI interview before submitting; a completed interview can be reused for other listings	Use the practice interview; one strong interview serves many listings	link
WS002	Mercor	OFFICIAL	PAY	Paid weekly via Stripe to a bank account in your own name; USD contracts	Set up Stripe/bank details early to avoid first-payout delays	link
WS003	Mercor	REVIEWS	SUCCESS	Reviewers praise weekly pay, good rates on some contracts, thorough training on some projects	Pay reliability is a strength; project availability is not	link
WS004	Mercor	REVIEWS	FAILURE	'You will apply and wait 2 weeks to 6 months to hear back'; availability 'highly inconsistent'	Apply to several listings and other platforms at once	link
WS005	Mercor	ANECDOTE	FAILURE	Users asking whether anyone was hired after the AI interview; repeated reports of no response	Silence is normal; don't wait on one platform	link
WS006	Mercor	JOURNALISM	PAY	After a project ended, workers were offered a similar project ('Nova') at $16/hr, $5 less than before; some had earned up to $60/hr on other projects. Mercor called the report inaccurate	Project rates are temporary; confirm each new rate	link
WS007	Mercor	JOURNALISM	SUCCESS	Mercor hired 30,000+ contractors in 2025; some contractors described the work as a way out of unemployment	Domain expertise is the ticket in	link
WS008	Mercor / AI training	JOURNALISM	RISK	Contractors removed for using AI tools/Grammarly/AI translation on tasks; contracts prohibit LLM use	Never use AI to produce task answers	link
WS009	DataAnnotation	OFFICIAL/REVIEWS	PROCESS	Starter Assessment ~1 hr, unpaid, one attempt; if you do not pass you may hear nothing	Prepare like an exam; one shot	link
WS010	DataAnnotation	ANECDOTE	PAY	Hourly projects become payable ~7 days after submission, per-task ~3 days; take all qualifications to see more projects	Complete every qualification to unlock more work	link
WS011	DataAnnotation	REVIEWS	SUCCESS	4.1/5 on both; reviewers say 'payment is prompt and problem free'; flexible remote work	Strongest pay-reliability evidence among generalist platforms	link
WS012	DataAnnotation	REVIEWS	FAILURE	Assessment unanswered for weeks; one worker blocked after three years without explanation	Diversify; keep your own records of work	link

ID	Platform	Type	Pattern	What happened	Lesson	Src
WS013	DataAnnotation	ANECDOTE	SUCCESS	After acceptance, completed 2 paid qualification tasks at $15 each; new projects appeared about 2 days later	Paid qualifications are the gateway to projects	link
WS014	DataAnnotation / Surge AI	JOURNALISM	RISK	Lawsuit alleges misclassification as contractors (minimum wage, overtime). Allegations only	You are a 1099 contractor: budget for taxes	link
WS015	Outlier	OFFICIAL	PROCESS	General onboarding 30–90 minutes: account, expertise, skill screening, ID verification; project onboarding varies	Block 2 focused hours for onboarding	link
WS016	Outlier	JOURNALISM	PAY	'I logged in and suddenly my pay dropped from $50 to $15' an hour on generalist projects; work slowed afterward	Generalist rates can be cut overnight; specialize	link
WS017	Outlier	REVIEWS	FAILURE	Strong quality scores and invitation to advanced project, then warning that accounts 'can be deactivated at any time based on opaque automated flags'	Never depend on a single platform	link
WS018	Outlier	ANECDOTE	PAY	PayPal/AirTM payments generally arrived by Wednesday morning ET; direct deposit slower; others reported weeks of pending balances	Use a verified PayPal with name matching your profile	link
WS019	Outlier	REVIEWS	FAILURE	Empty queue (no tasks) is the most common complaint; generalist volume thinned as work shifts to experts	Expect gaps; keep applying elsewhere	link
WS020	Alignerr	REVIEWS	SUCCESS	AI interviewer 'Zara' understood resume and asked experience-specific questions; responsive team leads; clear pay info	Prepare resume stories for the AI interviewer	link
WS021	Alignerr	REVIEWS	FAILURE	~6 hours of work on a code-preference project, no feedback for six weeks, then removed without pay; another reports ~$1.3k missing after pay-structure change; rates fell over time	Log hours and task IDs; stop after first unpaid cycle	link
WS022	Handshake AI	OFFICIAL	PROCESS	Rolling review; applying does not guarantee a project; matched fellows complete a paid training exercise; projects can start, pause, or end on short notice; strong contributors may become reviewers	Treat matching as competitive; quality earns reviewer roles	link
WS023	Handshake AI	OFFICIAL	SUCCESS	University career office promotes the fellowship to US-based master's/PhD students and graduates in all fields	Ask your career office; it is an official channel	link
WS024	micro1	REVIEWS	SUCCESS	4.8/5; praise for flexibility and the work; pay & benefits 4.7	Apply to specific listings	link
WS025	micro1	REVIEWS	FAILURE	Called the AI interview unimpressive; offered a low-rate generic annotator contract despite high self-assessment score; paid only for typing time	Negotiate within posted range; clarify what time is billable	link

ID	Platform	Type	Pattern	What happened	Lesson	Src
WS026	xAI	JOURNALISM	RISK	≥500 generalist data annotators laid off; paid through contract end or Nov 30; xAI said it would grow specialist tutors 10X	Generalist AI-training roles are fragile; specialist roles more durable	link
WS027	AI training (sector)	JOURNALISM	MARKET	AI startups (Mercor, Surge, Scale, Turing) recruiting white-collar experts as gig talent	Laid-off professionals can monetize domain expertise	link
WS028	Prolific	OFFICIAL	PAY	Studies must pay at least $8/hr; recommended $12/hr	Low ceiling but reliable	link
WS029	Prolific	ANECDOTE	SUCCESS	One poster logged Prolific $254.83 in Nov 2025 and $324–$499/month earlier in 2025; others reported $147, $360, and ~$11	Wide variance; good filler, not a salary	link
WS030	TELUS Digital	OFFICIAL	RISK	TELUS says it never requests deposits or fees; fake recruiters ask for 'Premium ID' fees	Any fee request = scam	link
WS031	Upwork	ANECDOTE	SUCCESS	'About 2 months to land my first client, and 3 weeks after that to land my next'	Expect weeks, not days; second client comes faster	link
WS032	Upwork	ANECDOTE	FAILURE	Sent proposals for 6 months before first job; others sent 'hundreds' of proposals with no reply until profile changes	Fix profile/niche before buying more Connects	link
WS033	Upwork	OFFICIAL	SUCCESS	'I made my profile in July 2021, I landed my first client in October 2021'	Persistence over ~3 months is a common pattern	link
WS034	Upwork	ANECDOTE	SUCCESS	Sent first proposals May 10; hired May 16 on a job with 20–50 proposals; only applicant messaged	A specific, fast proposal can beat volume; treat promotional claims cautiously	link
WS035	Upwork	OFFICIAL	PROCESS	Identity verification is often requested after the first contract; freelancers get jobs without the badge	Don't wait for verification to start applying	link
WS036	Fiverr	ANECDOTE	SUCCESS	First order after about three weeks despite many impressions and clicks	Impressions ≠ orders; refine gig thumbnail, title, price	link
WS037	Fiverr	ANECDOTE	SUCCESS	Got first order and immediately two repeat orders from the same buyer	Over-deliver on order #1 to earn repeats	link
WS038	Fiverr	ANECDOTE	FAILURE	Gig created April 2024, first order within a week, then no orders for three months; a returning seller with 50 past orders got none after updating gigs	Fiverr alone is unreliable; pair with outreach	link
WS039	Job search (remote)	ANECDOTE	FAILURE	By late September: 152 applications, 6 company interviews, 51 rejections, 101 ghosted	Cold applications alone convert poorly	link

ID	Platform	Type	Pattern	What happened	Lesson	Src
WS040	Job search (remote)	JOURNALISM	SUCCESS	Needed 1,000+ applications before landing a better remote role; says she would cast a narrower net from the start	Targeted beats mass applying	link
WS041	Job search (remote)	ANECDOTE	SUCCESS	53 applications, 52 rejections, 1 offer (Jan–Jun 2025); another poster's offer came through personal network, LinkedIn recruiter leads converted better	Network and recruiter leads outperform cold applications	link
WS042	Job search (market)	DATA	MARKET	Median time to first offer 68.5 days (+22%); 20.8% of users needed 10–20 applications; 14.3% needed 100+	Plan for ~2–3 months for stable employment	link
WS043	Job search (market)	DATA	MARKET	Remote jobs were 8.4% of LinkedIn postings but drew 42% of applications; hybrid 13.5% / 19.5%	Remote roles are ~5x more contested; apply early and use referrals	link
WS044	Job search (market)	DATA	MARKET	Nearly 70% call the market extremely or very competitive; 7% think it favors candidates	Competition is the norm, not your failure	link
WS045	Job scams	DATA	RISK	Task-scam reports rose from ~0 (2020) to ~5,000 (2023) to ~20,000 in H1 2024; job-scam losses >$220M in H1 2024	Never pay to get paid; ignore unsolicited WhatsApp/text job offers	link
WS046	Job scams	OFFICIAL	RISK	Task-scam network used fake 'recruiter' and 'mentor' personas and Telegram 'training'; victims paid in before 'earnings'	A 'mentor' on Telegram is a red flag	link
WS047	Arise	JOURNALISM	RISK	Agents paid for training, equipment and platform fees; D.C. AG sued alleging misclassification and pay practices	Prefer W-2 employers for customer service	link
WS048	Liveops	OFFICIAL	RISK	$25 background check paid by applicant; certification unpaid; talk-time 25–34¢/min on some programs; no guaranteed earnings	Compute real hourly before paying	link
WS049	Rev	REVIEWS	PROCESS	Test = transcription part + English multiple choice; described as easy; no feedback after assessment	Fast to start, low effective pay	link
WS050	UserTesting	REVIEWS	PROCESS	$10 tests disappear quickly once opened; company says reward is shown upfront and tests are first-come-first-served	Turn on notifications	link
WS051	Federal jobs	JOURNALISM	MARKET	Jan 2025 executive order ended most federal remote work and froze hiring; 2026 targeted thaw	Don't rely on federal remote roles for urgent income	link

Appendix C: Sources, Method & Limitations

Method. Research was carried out on October 21–22, 2026 using web search across official company pages, help centers, official job boards (Greenhouse, Lever, company portals), news reporting, review sites, and community forums. Each directory row cites the URLs that support it.

Limitations you should know about.

1. **Pages were verified through search indexes, not by clicking through applications.** Direct page fetches and Reddit were not reachable from the research environment. Reddit threads were read through indexed read-only mirrors, and the original reddit.com URLs are cited.
2. **Pay figures change frequently.** Many come from listing copies on job aggregators or from third-party reviews, and each is labeled with its source type in the CSV (`pay_source`).
3. **Some application links point to a platform's home or careers page** rather than a deep application URL where the deep link could not be confirmed. Look for "Apply," "Join," or "Careers" on the page.
4. **Worker anecdotes are self-reported** and can be promotional. They show possibilities and patterns, not probabilities.
5. **Legal and tax notes are general information**, not legal or tax advice. Confirm details with IRS.gov, your state agency, or a professional.

The full list of unresolved items is in `FACT_CHECK.md`.

Official public resources referenced

- FTC job-scam data and reporting: ftc.gov · ReportFraud.ftc.gov
- FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center: ic3.gov
- U.S. Department of Labor, CareerOneStop & American Job Centers: careeronestop.org
- Health coverage after job loss: HealthCare.gov
- IRS self-employment tax and estimated payments: irs.gov (Form 1040-ES)